

Book by Judith: The Power of
the Sacred living Letters.

THE POWER OF THE SACRED LIVING LETTERS



THE KABBALAH BOOK OF CHANGE



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Sacred Living Letters Body Complete, pdf
created 18 Jan 12

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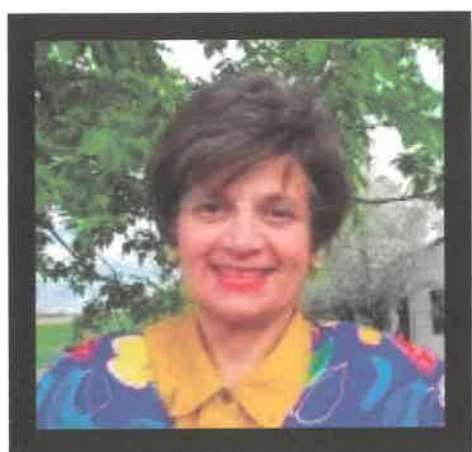
WITH JASMYNE BOSWELL

AND YEHUDIS FISHMAN



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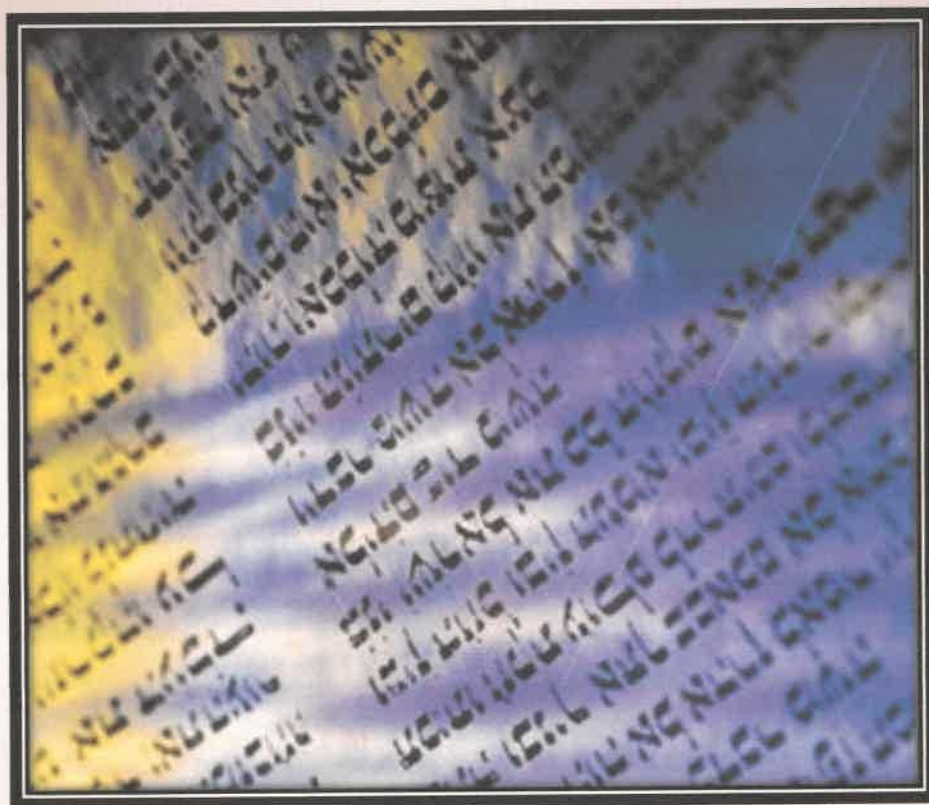


Yehudis Fishman has been teaching Torah and Chassidic writings for over forty years to students of all ages and backgrounds both on the east coast and the Midwest. She has been a director of several Jewish organizations in Santa Fe and Colorado. Her articles, and poetry on a wide variety of Jewish interest have been printed in many publications as well as on the web. She currently resides in Boulder Colorado where she is known as 'Morah at large.'

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Acknowledgements and Thanks

With gratitude to Hashem for transmitting whatever wisdom we've been able to acquire during the process of writing this book. Any genius that this book contains came through us not of us. We acknowledge our families for gifting us the curiosity and tenacity to become Rebellious Jewish women so we could take on the enormous task of writing this book. Of course we include our friends, families and spiritual communities for supporting us through this process. And we'd like to express our appreciation and gratitude to Yehudis Fishman without whom this book would never have been written with the authentic Kabbalistic teachings. Her Chassidic, Lubavitch, Hamisha presence allowed us to learn as we wrote and infused us with the joys of being Jewish.

A Note from Judith

A profound heartfelt thank you to Melissa Stuart for supporting the publication of this manuscript and to Kirsten Rae Erkfritz for her tireless energy and skill in editing, formatting and making space for me to complete this version of the Sacred Living Letters.

THE POWER OF THE LIVING LETTERS

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Preface to Power of the Sacred Living Letters

I feel like I have been somehow preparing my whole life to help with this book. As an only child, I attended a modern Orthodox day school, on top of a very ancient synagogue in Roxbury Mass. I remember on the first day of school how intimidated I felt by the thick heavy doors that led to the synagogue, and the winding staircase I needed to climb to get to my class. However, once I was settled into the first grade and exposed to those unusual shapes called the Alef-Bet, I became the fastest Hebrew reader in the class. Even at that young age, these exotic letters seemed to become my constant companions. They bore for me an instant fascination. I rolled them over my tongue and savored them like the sugar candy on a stick that was given in those days for little girls with sore throats. I even doodled and daydreamed with them during some boring classes.

However, it was not till seventh grade that I suddenly became aware of the inner power of the Hebrew Alphabet. A second door opened for me. I was wandering around the Public Gardens near downtown Boston when I spotted a gold dome glistening in the sun. I was magnetically drawn to that building, but when I got there, what entranced me more than the golden domed Boston state house, was an old library behind it. Being somewhat of a bookworm, I fumbled for my library card and wandered into the building. It looked like an ordinary library with each room containing books on different topics. Soon however, I spotted a thick ornately carved wooden door that seemed tightly closed.

Like any curious pre-teen, I wondered what lie behind those doors, and surreptitiously turned the handles. A vaguely familiar smell assailed me. It smelled like schnapps and herring, a smell that I had encountered only in old synagogues. I looked around and sure enough there were shelves and shelves of old and even some tattered Hebrew and Jewish books. Following my nose, I was led to one shelf where all the books were Hebrew except for one. It too was old and it had the word Kabbalah on the title. As I opened it, I found several pages of strange looking circles and lines that formed Kabbalistic diagrams from the Hebrew letters. I was transported back to that sense of mystery I had felt in the first grade when being shown the Hebrew alphabet. I took that book out of the library and 'smuggled' it into school, and began to read it during a class that was not too interesting. I got so absorbed in it; I did not notice till too late, that a teacher was looking over my shoulder. His mouth fell open and he exclaimed, 'Young lady, you should not be reading that at your age.' I heard peals of laughter, and you can well imagine what kind of book the rest of the class thought I the book was. As for me, the mystical and the romantic became inextricably entwined in my psyche from that day on.

I began looking for mystical Jewish texts in English, but in the late fifties, there were not many around. So I started applying myself more diligently to my Hebrew studies, with the secret hope of someday being able to master some of those 'off limit esoteric books, in their original language. I cautiously consulted with a few people who I trusted not to poke fun at me or 'expose' me, and they advised me to study Chassidic texts first, since Chassidic writings were a more user friendly adaptation of Kabbalistic concepts. One of the first books I found was a Hebrew commentary on Pirkei Avot, Ethics of the Fathers from teachings of the Baal Shem Tov, the founder of the Chassidic movement. Each idea was like finding a precious jewel, but the one that intrigued me the most was the following:

The primary text reads: (Chapter 6, paragraph 3) Whoever learns from his friend one chapter, or one law, or one verse or one phrase, or even one letter, needs to give honor to his friend. The teaching then goes on to give an example from King David. David learned only two matters from his teacher Achitophel, who later turned against David and became less than righteous. Still David in Psalm 55, referred to him with the following words: 'A man my equal, my teacher, and my distinguished one.' If so, continues the Mishnah, how much more should we respect one who teaches even one letter.

The Baal Shem Tov asks a few questions: 1) Why does the Mishnah stress 'ONLY' two matters? 2) How can we derive the idea of learning 'even ONE letter' from King David, if he learned TWO matters from Achitophel? The Baal Shem Tov gives an answer that I remember felt like a bolt of lightning through my whole being when I first read it.

'When a person learns from an unworthy teacher, then the only thing that is being transmitted is, to use a modern term, 'an information byte, and nothing more.' But when learning from someone righteous, of a higher consciousness, the words are like a living seed that keeps growing and growing inside the person receiving. Therefore, since Achitophel was not so holy, the two teachings that David got from him were non-organic. Still, David honored him for even those two teachings alone. Therefore, how much more so should we honor someone who provides us with a life-filled, vibrant teaching of Torah.

The Baal Shem Tov added that at Mount Sinai, Israel received the Ten Commandments. Rabbi Saadia Gaon, who some say was reincarnated into the Baal Shem Tov, says that the entire Torah was compressed into the Ten Commandments. Similarly, adds the Baal Shem Tov, the Ten Commandments were compressed into the first word, ANOCHI, I AM. Finally, the word itself ANOCHI was compressed into the first letter ALEPH, which 'happens' to be the first letter of the Hebrew alphabet. So concludes the Chassidic master, if the soul of a teacher is connected to the Oneness of Hashem, then if even one letter is being taught, that letter leads the student through the portal of the whole alphabet and into the unity of the Torah and of Divine wisdom.

That teaching itself was for me a portal both to my past and future. As a child, being a Torah teacher was the last thing I wanted to be. It seemed so ordinary and mundane, kind of like being a secretary. But my Hebrew and Judaic teachers were for me gateways to the treasures and mysteries of that spiritual DNA called the Aleph Beit. So I think I decided, after the seed of the Baal Shem Tov's teaching was planted in me, to dedicate my life trying to become the kind of teacher that the Baal Shem Tov was talking about- a teacher that could open doors of the heart and soul, a teacher that could illuminate the meaning of one's small life as well as life written large, and a teacher who would scatter those living seeds of the Aleph Beit throughout the entire Universe, and lead all people back to the Oneness of G-d.

When Judith and Jasmyne invited me to assist them in this awesome project, my dream took a quantum leap toward its fulfillment.

INTRODUCTION TO THE POWER OF THE SACRED LIVING LETTERS

Kabbalah means “to receive, to accept,” and is synonymous with the word ‘tradition’. The Kabbalah comes to us as a secret oral tradition, possessing the hidden meanings, mystical understanding, and divine concealed power of the Torah. The scholars’ and Kabbalists who study the Kabbalah believe the secrets of the creation of the Universe reside there.

Many religious people, both Jewish and Christian, believe the Jewish Bible, the Torah, is divine, given to Moses directly from God. In this book, we will refer to God as Hashem, which means ‘the name’. There are at least 72 names for God and Hashem is one that everyone can use, no matter their background. According to Jewish tradition, the Torah existed prior to the creation of the world. Because the word Torah is feminine in Hebrew, “She,” the Torah advised God on the creation of the human being. Along with the written words of the Torah given to Moses, was its oral companion, the Kabbalah, passed down from generation to generation. Although there is no proof, many believe that the Kabbalah has been available since the time of Adam and that Abraham was the first to record it.

We present a taste of this rich tradition and wisdom by focusing on the letters of the Hebrew alphabet, called the Alef-Bet. Learning to use them in everyday life as taught in the Kabbalah will make every decision more meaningful. The letters are the same ones used to create the universe, and when we interact with them, they emit an energy that connects with our life essence.

The Kabbalah teaches that the world was created with the Hebrew Alef-Bet. Hashem whispered them and from each breath, came more of the world. Each letter remains alive and continues to exert its power and influence in every aspect of our world. By choosing to focus on sacred living letters and study them, all possibilities to spiritual fulfillment are attainable. The Kabbalah also reminds us this earth is a home for Hashem as well as for all other creatures. All we need to do is look at a flower or listen to a bird and we can feel the truth of this.

As recently as 50 years ago, the Kabbalah was inaccessible to most. This source of wisdom was a tradition passed down to learned Jewish men over the age of 40 who had been immersed in their religious practices from birth. The reasons given for this Jewish law, range from the lofty to the pragmatic. On one hand, the content was seen as potentially dangerous for the novice because it was believed that unless one was pure in heart, deep in learning, and practicing the laws and rituals of the religion, they could manipulate the material in the Kabbalah for selfish ends. Another reason given was that without this deep understanding, the value of

the Kabbalah was questionable. Yet there are exceptions. The renowned Kabbalist R. Isaac Luria (1534-1572) was only seventeen when he began to study Kabbalah. He died at the age of thirty-eight, two years before the tradition allowed the study of this mystical tradition. His equally famous contemporary R. Moses Cordovero (1522-1570) began his study of Kabbalah when only twenty. If we search throughout history, we discover that many famous Kabbalists started early in their quest. We don't know how many women or children studied Kabbalah.

The last Lubavitcher Rebbe, Menachem Mendel Schneerson, decided to spread the word of the Kabbalah so that all people could benefit from the wisdom it contained. A Rebbe is held higher than a rabbi. He is considered the spiritual Jewish leader of a particular generation. Rebbe Schneerson believed the time had come for this learning to be made available to all. Its relevance spreads across gender, religion, age and level of scholarship. Many scholars who have spent their lifetime studying the Kabbalah say although their lives are rich with positive experiences and deep meaning, they realize just how much they still do not know.

The Power of the Sacred Living Letters infuses ancient Kabbalistic teachings with the modern concept of 'emotional intelligence' and non-dual practices. Emotional intelligence is the ability of a person to know what they are feeling and how it affects them in the moment. Non-dual practices allow the practitioner to sit with that which is unknowable and find inner peace. *The Power of the Sacred Living Letters* is an integration of ancient Kabbalistic wisdom, emotional intelligence, non-dual wisdom and depth psychology designed to engage your mind, body, spirit, and emotions. Depth psychology is the study and integration of the unconscious mind. Each letter offers you the opportunity to experience movement, growth and an aha. You can experience this by understanding many aspects including the "shadow" of each letter and choosing to follow the "right actions" presented in each chapter. There are many ideas presented in this book that are outside the purview of the Kabbalah itself, such as the practical applications of the letters. We do our best to let you know when these ideas come directly from the Kabbalah.

Only God exists without paradox. We differentiate between light and dark, negative and positive, right and wrong, young and old just to name a few. Part of the human condition is to see the world through a lens of duality. In the *Sacred Living Letters*, opposites such as light and dark, right and wrong, good and bad, are shown to be equal in their point of view and dissolved into oneness as you sit with each letter and can experience these polarities as a range of color in a spectrum. The information and exercises in the book creates a sacred space to explore these paradoxes in relevant and spontaneous ways.

Our book has a practical application for everyday questions as well as deeper spiritual yearnings. It is knowledge and intuition based and derived from traditional, psychological and spiritual sources. This guided personal exploration ensures actions that lead to relevant and lasting results. Using these 'Sacred Letters'

to accompany your spiritual journey will affirm and validate your innate wisdom. It will benefit novices as well as those well along their spiritual path.

In the Kabbalistic tradition, nothing is “real” until an action takes place. Just as Hashem created this world with his breath, so we create our world with our actions. We all take action in every aspect of our life, from marriage and significant relationships, to parenting, business, and community. We often separate spiritual practice from the process of daily living. However, when we connect to the core of our being and integrate our spiritual, emotional, and practical selves, our life and the spiritual merge. There is no path, there is just life.

The Torah as well as the Kabbalah clearly states that the letters of the Hebrew alphabet are the original source of creation. Biblical scholars know the Hebrew language as the “holy tongue.” Many spiritual teachers from various faiths and practices say that studying the Alef-Bet, the Sacred Living Letters, is a way of understanding how the universe was created. From our everyday experience and collective knowledge, we know studying the Alef-Bet and naturally using the letters in our life will assist us to live as fully as possible. As an added benefit, you may begin to understand the spiritual DNA of the universe in an openhearted way.

According to Jewish tradition, the Hebrew Alef-Bet is sacred and holds unique and inestimable significance because:

1. it preceded existence and is, the vehicle for the continued process of creation – whether the content is physical, emotional, intellectual or spiritual, these letters continue to create our lives, whether we are aware of it or not
2. the language of the Hebrew Bible is made up of the Alef- Bet, Hashem’s original speech
3. it is used to communicate religious prayer and ceremony through Hashem’s language, creating a direct line to His essence
4. the shape, sound and meaning are logically and mystically intertwined.

There is an Ancient mystical text entitled *Sefer Yetzirah*, the Book of Formation. Some scholars claim Adam or Abraham wrote this book. An important idea in this manual of creation is, ‘The beginning is enwedged in the end, and the end in the beginning’. A similar idea is expressed in a mystical Hebrew prayer called ‘Lecha Dodi, Likrat Kala’, ‘Come my beloved to meet the bride.’ A key line in this ‘prayer is: ‘the end of action is the first in thought.’ Both of these concepts refer to a fundamental principle that has relevance in modern day personal and business relationships. The way we begin anything, whether it be a project, a relationship, a business, already has the seeds of the results planted within it at the start. By

learning about and using the Sacred Living Letters, you will be looking at your life with a more holistic attitude and a heightened capacity for joy.

An underlying concept of Kabbalah is that we each have a divine purpose. This purpose is accomplished through how we live our lives. It cannot occur by escaping or avoiding ordinary existence. There is a living God who is intimately involved in our lives. This means we live our life from a place of holiness. Once we recognize what we are, we can help make the world a better place. These connections may come to us through our thoughts, words, or deeds. The Hebrew Alef-Bet, the Sacred Living Letters, activate these connections.

Many sages have said that when you choose one of these letters, and perform the actions as suggested in each chapter of this book, you have an opportunity to reach even higher than the angels and touch the essence of Hashem. As humans, we are defined by the uniqueness of free will, which can be turned to a blessing or a curse, depending solely on our choice. We are commanded and obligated to 'choose life'. These words to 'choose life' are not just good advice, they are forces and energies that empower us to take right action when we listen and respond from the depths of our being.

The power of the Sacred Living Letters will help you to access the wisdom to turn to yourself for the answers you seek — both your universal and personal questions. This wisdom includes the sense and knowing that you are always supported. This book serves as a tool. It is now time to begin your personal journey working with the source of creation, the "Sacred Living Letters."

Entering the Sacred Path

Dear Readers,

You have decided to enter the mystical journey of the Power of the Sacred Letters. You may or may not know why you have been drawn to experience this path. The road is sacred and holy. In the world of Judaism and the Kabbalah, the more we ground ourselves in the mundane, everyday, physical world, the more spiritual, sacred space we make for our life.

There are many ways to get started.

1. Go to the page at the back of this book where you will find the letters of the Aleph-Bet. Simply remove all the letters from the page, put them in a bag and work with the one you draw.

2. Start at the front of the book and study it cover to cover.
3. Fan through the book stopping at the page you are most drawn to or pick one of the accompanying cards.
4. Form a study group or Havarah.
5. Use the teachings as bookends for your day. Study one of the letters upon waking in the morning and reflect upon it before you go to bed at night.
6. Read a portion of the book to create sacred space prior to your daily meditation.
7. Utilize the letters to inspire your creativity and spiritual practice.
8. Find other ways that serve you best and share them with us for the benefit of other students of the Sacred Letters.

Each chapter begins with a story. Our suggestion for the best way to absorb the power of each letter is to:

- Read the story prior to delving into the letter. It will metaphorically introduce you to the deep mystical meaning that particular letter holds.
- Read the letter through once to get its larger perspective. On the second reading, answer the questions and see what meaning they have for you.
- Once you have understood the shadow aspect of the letter, go to right actions. See which one(s) draws you.
- If you get stuck or feel bored or frustrated—no need to despair. That may be part of your journey.
- Repeat this process until you feel complete with the letter you have chosen. Then choose again.

The Kabbalists say that studying the Hebrew Alef-Bet is tantamount to living in a parallel reality. You are on your way.



Rabbi Dovber of Meseritch, successor of the Baal Shem Tov, was once approached by two of his disciples, the brothers Reb Pinchas and Reb Shmelke. They asked how it could be that a person is expected to bless G-d for negative experiences in the same way as blessing Him for positive experiences. Instead of answering them, the Rabbi sent them to another one of his disciples, Reb Zisha. The brothers traveled a long distance till they came to the city where Zisha lived in Anopoli and finally found the ram shackled hut of Reb Zisha. There was barely any furniture and the hut was falling apart. They finally got up the courage to approach Reb Zisha with their question. Reb Zisha shook his head and replied, "I can't really understand why our rebbe sent you to me. I haven't had a day of suffering in my entire life"

Alef

Meaning: Leader, Paradox

Focus: To enhance connection with Hashem

Number: 1, 1000

Calendar Connection: Autumn

When you choose Alef, it means you are ready to leave your internal Egypt. Alef is the first letter in the Hebrew Alef-Bet and the first letter in the Ten Commandments. The commandment reads, "I the Lord am your God who brought you out of the land of Egypt, the house of bondage." Whether you are a slave to thoughts, patterns of negative emotions, or your life style, at this moment you are centered on a precipice ready to jump. You have chosen to unite with who you really are, so you have also chosen to become one with Hashem.

The Kabbalah tells us Hashem conceals Himself in every aspect of the earth, from a grain of sand to the highest peak in the Himalayas. The shape of the Alef also conceals Hashem's name, just as He is concealed in this world. The shape of the letter includes two other Hebrew letters, Yud and Vav. Look at the letter. The upper

section, the Yud, represents the space of heaven and the waters above --- the lower section, Yud, represents the space of earth and the waters below. The upper waters are the waters of joy; the lower waters are the waters of bitterness. The middle connector, the Vav, represents the space between heaven and earth. This unites and separates two opposites similar to the yin/yang of the Chinese tradition. This is the secret of the image in which man was created.

The Alef has no sound of its own as it represents Hashem's essence, the transcendent core of existence, and all the other letters act as a ring around and a portal to the Alef. Therefore, each time you choose a letter and take the right actions associated with that letter, you touch the essence of Hashem.

Angels surround Hashem and are messengers transforming spirit to matter, and we can reach higher than the angels. When you choose the letter Alef, you enter into this metaphysical paradox. On the one hand, this is an inner experience without physical form or substance. On the other hand, we are united with Hashem in the physical through his spark that is present in each of us. Hashem is ultimate reality.

Can you see the paradox in the shape of Alef?

How do you connect with this paradox?

How do we reach higher than the angels?

Hashem made an agreement with our soul that by doing "right action" we can reach even higher than the heavens and live connected to Him. This "right action" is called a Mitzvah, the action connection. This includes laws about food and the Jewish Sabbath as well as acts of kindness and giving to others. When you do what Hashem asks, you have made that connection, whether you feel it or not.

Alef represents the core of the soul as well as the core of the letters. By choosing Alef now, it means you are ready to heal your experience of separation and be the leader of your spiritual journey. Remember, it is only your illusion that perceives separation or duality between you and Hashem. Quantum physics, as well as the Kabbalah reminds us we are not solid, or separate. Rather, we are already one and just need to recognize ourselves.

Have you had an experience of being connected to Hashem?

Can you remember what that felt like?

This illusion of separateness between you and Hashem or between you and others can be healed in a moment. Choosing Alef also means you are ready to include Hashem in all relationships.

How can you do this?

What are the consequences of not doing this?

The number for Alef is one.

- One God
- First number that can be counted
- One nation indivisible

Shadow aspect of Alef

- Passivity is a shadow aspect of Alef. The silent letter Alef turned against itself allows for passivity that spirals downwards leading to violence. Many victims of domestic violence or negative relationships retreat and disconnect demonstrating this passivity. They do not stand up for themselves. They wait until someone explodes.
- Judgment always presents itself through a belief in separation. Whether you are judging others or yourself, you are engaging in a deep form of self-abuse. Seeing fault and separation in situations is common in this shadow aspect of Alef. This also includes disrespect, dishonoring the spark of Hashem in all creation.
- Indulgence of repetitive thinking, support of emotional negativity and argument for the sake of being right is another shadow aspect of Alef. A chaotic internal life may be familiar; yet if you continue allowing your negative emotions and thinking to consume you, you are turning your heart and your divine spark into a modern day Egypt.

Right Actions for Alef

- Take a moment to move into silence. From that silence, listen to your thinking. Are your silence and the silence of the Alef any different? Write down your discoveries
- Actively participate. Do this even when you don't feel like it. You will discover much about yourself.
- Become a leader and stand up for someone when injustice occurs, even when feeling fear. It is really standing up for you. Not standing up because of fear usually creates more fear and possibly even shame.

- Defend a cause that you believe in even if it is unpopular. By doing this, you have the opportunity to tip the scales and be the one who makes a difference. Be the power of Alef.



A disciple came to a Rabbi and asked, "I understand how a person is expected to control their actions and words, but how is a person supposed to control their thoughts?" Instead of answering him directly, the Rabbi sent him to another Rabbi. It was in the middle of winter and the disciple arrived in the dead of night, saw a light in the window, knocked and knocked on the door. It was bitter cold but no one answered. Finally, after a few hours when the disciple was shivering with cold, the Rabbi opened the door and the disciple said, "I saw your light on and knew you were up. Why didn't you open the door when I knocked?" The Rabbi responded with a smile and said, "It's my home and therefore I can choose to let in whomever I want whenever I want or even choose not to let anyone in."

Beit

Meaning: Home of the Material and Physical – Hashem's dwelling

Focus: Bringing together of opposites to create a common place

Number: 2

Calendar Connection: Sunday – 1st day of the week

When you choose Beit, you are ready to enhance the holiness of your home. Beit is the second letter in the Hebrew Alef-Bet, yet it is the first letter of the first word in the Torah. This word is Bereishit and means "In a beginning." Thus begins the description of creation. We learn from Kabbalah that Hashem created a home, a Beit here on earth for himself and all creatures. He asks us treat all the earth as "holy space." This blessing of the earth comes from prayer and "right actions."

When you make your home holy, Hashem can live with you. As you make this choice, you can experience a deeper passion in all areas of your life. Since this

passion stems from holiness, it cannot be extinguished no matter what your experience.

The Kabbalah teaches that Beit's passion is the nourishing, primal, universal energy that brings forth life. Choosing Beit lets you know you can accept your natural birthright of holiness and passion for Hashem to actualize. With Beit alive in your heart, your everyday decisions will reflect a positive perspective. Negative habits can dissolve as quickly as a morning mist in the sunlight.

What negative habit can be dissolved to experience your natural passion?

Hashem states in the Torah, "they shall build me a temple and I will dwell in them." It continues to clarify He was talking about dwelling in our real home, our body. Hashem wants intimate relationships with us; unlike any other creatures, we have the gift of free will. The story goes that up until the time we were created, Hashem lived with the angels, programmed to praise Him constantly. We, on the other hand, feel, think, and act. We can learn and grow, and freely choose to open our hearts and home for Hashem. As we do this, our relationships naturally transform... This is an opening for Hashem to express Himself more fully. Remember, we are made in His image.

Do you know anyone, who, like the angels, always agrees with you? What is it like to be with them?

What is the state of your "internal home?"

The gift of free will is also a gift of potentiality. There is the potential for a life of love and joy as well as one of negativity and loneliness. Although you may already be happy and joyful, by choosing Beit, you have also chosen unlimited potential, a life filled with holiness and Hashem.

How do you make room for Hashem in your life?

Our understanding of holiness may include aspects of separation from the practical world. Yet, we all have the opportunity to create holiness everywhere by how we live our lives. There is no need to go anywhere or do anything. When we create a holy space, we discover that Hashem is already there.

What is your definition of holiness?

What is your definition of free will?

What is your connection between the two?

Your challenge is to choose conscious behaviors that facilitate a home for Hashem in your heart. Although he is already there, albeit in a concealed form, taking the time to invite him in can bring you closer to openheartedness.

How often do you see Hashem in yourself or others?

Describe this?

The number for Beit is two, the number of duality or paradox.

1. Day and night
2. Light and dark
3. Man and woman
4. Love and hate
5. Earth and sky

Our human condition is a morass of contradictions, paradox and dichotomy. Within the world of Hashem, these disappear. In the new science of Quantum Physics, dichotomies do not exist. This meeting of modern physics and the Kabbalah is very timely as we learn more about our connection with Hashem.

Have you had a recent experience of dissolving a dichotomy?

How would you describe it?

The analogy, “as within, so without,” can be observed in your physical surroundings, as your home and life is a reflection of your inner emotional and spiritual life. Since you are in the image of Hashem, it follows that as you make your inner and outer home more holy, you will change how you experience life. You are ready to invite Hashem into your soul, into your home and into your everyday life.

What can you do to invite Hashem into your home?

What can you do to make the earth a holy place?

Shadow aspect of Beit:

- Competition for being the holiest is a shadow aspect of Beit. It can represent a battle for the idea that your vision of Hashem is better than another's. It assumes that humans are separate. This is a negation of the first commandment and has been the cause of wars, inquisitions, and death. Holiness is holiness, the Lord is One, and cannot be anything but what it is. Competing for holiness can only lead to pain, despair, and a lack of joy.

- Beit is a feminine letter. It can reflect the shadow aspects of feminine energy. This may appear as a compelling need to manipulate and control others. When this shadow aspect is present, you may feel your spirit being smothered and suffocated. This experience can be difficult to stop because it perpetuates itself by not feeling satisfied.
- If you allow yourself to behave in a cowardly manner, or interfere with other people's life choices, you support a shadow side of Beit. There is a fine line between doing the right thing in a crisis or life or death situation, and thinking you know what's best and interfering with someone else's life path.

Right Actions for Beit

Be mindful to create a home for Hashem. Some ways to accomplish this in your external world are:

- Eat food that nourishes your body.
- Thank Hashem and be grateful for what you have in your life.
- Show appreciation to the people you share your life with. Include all of Hashem's creatures and creation in your appreciation.
- Create simplicity in your home.

Some ways to accomplish this in your internal world are:

- Take moments each day to sit quietly and notice life
- Clear your mind of old rubble replacing it with forgiveness and appreciation.
- Notice the paradoxes in your life. Watch how they dance in your mind.

A Simple Meditation

- Sit quietly for 20 minutes each day. During that time, as your thoughts move, watch them come and go.
- Bring to mind those people to whom you have begrudged your love or judged. Appreciate how they have contributed to your life. Notice how you can hold this paradox.



A Rabbi went to the home of a very wealthy miser to collect a donation for the poor. Undaunted by the miser's reputation, the Rabbi went in, guided the rich man to the window, and asked him, "What do you see?" The rich man said, "I see people walking back and forth." Then the Rabbi took him to a mirror and said, "What do you see now?" The miser answered, "I see myself." The Rabbi shook his head and wisely said, "I guess that's what the trouble is. Both the mirror and the window are pieces of glass. When you cover glass with silver a person only sees himself.

Gimmel

Meaning: Camel, bestowal, weaning

Focus: To emulate Hashem and give to others

Number: 3

Calendar Connection: Monday – 2nd day of the week

When you choose Gimmel, it means you are ready to embark on a new spiritual journey. Your spiritual depth and growth is such that you are now capable of nurturing others. There are three stages of growth; the first is dependency, like that of a child to a parent; the second is assertion of independence, like a teenager with a parent; and the third is when you are able to nurture others and be nurtured by them simultaneously. That is called interdependence. It takes you to new levels of intimacy and response-ability.

Which of these three stages of development best describes you?

One of the meanings of Gimmel is Camel. The uniqueness of the Camel is that after drinking its fill, it has enough liquid stored in its body to cross a dessert. The camel is like a weaned child who has learned to nourish herself and is no longer dependent on constant nourishment from others. The camel can endure a lot of weight and stress. It can carry travelers across a desert on its back. By nourishing itself first, it is able to serve others. The Camel is in the third stage of growth, that of interdependence.

In today's society, nourishing yourself first is often interpreted as selfishness. However, it is impossible to nurture others if your well is dry. Like the Camel, it is important to fill yourself first so you can be of service to others. Only then, do others receive valuable nourishment from you. In this giving of yourself, you also receive nourishment. The Kabbalah teaches that when you give to others, a space opens inside of you and you become a channel for Hashem's blessings. Do you nourish yourself before you give?

What valuable nourishment do you provide for others?

The number for Gimmel is 3.

- the elements in human creation are a man, a woman, and Hashem
- humans have 3 souls - animal, rational, and transcendent
- our world stands on 3 pillars; Hashem, spiritual study, and acts of kindness
- the triangle, having 3 sides, is the strongest structure in the universe

Shadow aspect of Gimmel:

- Covert self-interest is a shadow side of Gimmel. At times, it is difficult to give to someone less fortunate than yourself and remain humble. It is easy to forget that there for the grace of God go you. Your motive for giving may come from wanting to be noticed, receiving recognition or applause. Yet, remember that you are always less fortunate than someone else.
- Arrogance, thoughtlessness, and self-importance while giving, represent a shadow side of Gimmel. When you give to feel better about yourself, whether conscious or unconscious, it tends to taint the outcome. If you give from this level of motivation, something feels lacking.
- Imposing your point of view on others is another shadow aspect of Gimmel. This occurs during conversations when you find yourself desperate to communicate your opinion. The other person's point of view becomes irrelevant. This need for control of the mindset of another is the opposite of nourishment and caring.

Right Actions for Gimmel:

- Be good to yourself, and experience your nourishing capability. Nurture yourself before you offer to another.
- Think of the people you know who are in need. Ask what they need before you give. It can be time, financial assistance, caring, advice, or even silence. Give to them in a way that supports both of you.
- Give anonymously and notice if you feel depleted or replenished. Giving in this manner is a form of selflessness. Be like Hashem. Conceal your presence.



The Hebrew Bible relates that when the Israelites came to the Red Sea after running away from Egypt, they were surrounded on four sides and did not know what action to take in order to survive. In front of them was the sea, behind them were pursuing Egyptians, and on either side of them were marauders and wild creatures. They voiced various solutions to these dangers. One group said, "Let us give up." Another said, "Let's go back to Egypt. Another group said, "Let's fight." And the last group said, "Let's pray." Moses responded by saying that none of these ideas was right because they already had instructions from Hashem on what to do.

Dalet

Meaning: Door, passageway, poor man

Focus: Creating harmony in obligations

Number: 4

Calendar Connection: Tuesday – 3rd day of the week

When you choose Dalet, you are ready to open new doors. You have chosen to change your response to life's challenges. You can use your energy to restore your natural peacefulness and release overpowering negative thinking and internal wars.

What door have you been avoiding going through?

What transition have you resisted?

What stops you from moving forward?

Many people believe they can go through these passageways on their own without the help of Hashem. The Kabbalah teaches that any achievement in this world depends on right action and Divine aid.

What does this mean to you?

To eliminate struggle and be in harmony, you need the aid of Hashem. When you walk through the Divine door to meet the essence of Hashem, you also need Dalet, the symbol of a “humble spirit.”

Do you act as if you are alone, not needing Hashem?

Dalet is a sign of poverty. Poverty can mean many things: material poverty, poverty of the spirit, or of relationships. If you are experiencing poverty in any aspect of your life, you need to accept charity. Charity comes in many forms.

Notice how you feel when you read the word charity.

What does this mean to you?

Think about the blessing of accepting what is essential to go through the door of Dalet. Dalet teaches us to take direction from our inner knowing. On our path to the sacred, we come to know that physical reality is the doorway. Through Dalet, we learn to make choices that lead us there. No one way is the only way. There is a way that closely reflects your uniqueness. . Choosing Dalet tells us it is our time and sacred duty to find our way and stay true.

The number for Dalet is 4.

- 4 directions: north, south, east, and west
- 4 metaphysical worlds: emanation, creation, formation, and action
- 4 seasons of the year
- 4 Kabbalistic worlds
- 4 letters in Hashem’s innermost name

Shadow aspects of Dalet:

- Excessive humility is a shadow aspect of Dalet. If it is used as a way to receive praise and to be emotionally taken care of, it will produce disappointment and possibly despair. At times, it can infect relationship with a passive-aggressive stance that is emotionally devastating and spiritually false. If this humility is an illusion that substitutes for accepting help from Hashem, it can be experienced as cruelty and judgment from those in close proximity.
- Doorways are sacred. Another shadow aspect of Dalet is acting as if all doorways to resolve internal wars are closed. Behaving as a victim in relationships and in the material world creates the belief you are alone and cannot receive from the divine.
- Staying paralyzed in doorways, not making choices, or hiding your “poverty” from the world is another shadow aspect of Dalet. Staying put when it is clear you need to take action is a sign of fear taking hold.

Right Actions for Dalet:

- Look at the “doors” in your life you have refused to enter. Open one at a time and move through knowing Hashem is moving with you. Notice how that feels.
- Share that experience with a trusted friend.
- Talk with a person you have assumed is closed to you. Begin by being like Dalet. Be a door the person can move through. On the other side of that door, create the experience of acceptance and true humility. You know how to do it.
- Identify and resolve an internal war. Look at and examine all the possibilities of each side. Define the important issues. Choose the possibility that parallels your highest motivations and gives you an experience of harmony. Let all the other possibilities go free. Share the important lessons learned.



The story is told that when Perl, the wife of a well known Rabbi would bake Challot, the special braided bread for Shabbat, she would pray, "Master of the Universe, I beg of you, when my husband says the blessing over the bread, he has the same Holy intention that I am now putting into its preparation."

HEI

Meaning: Window, and the word "the"

Focus: Movement of thoughts into action - Connections between thought, mind, and action

Number: 5

Calendar Connection: Nisan – March/April

When you choose Hei, it means you are ready to explore your inner, feminine nature. This is the gap or space that occurs between your thoughts and your actions. This is true whether you are a man or a woman. This gap is existential and when you allow existential experiences into your life, it means you are strong

enough to delve into matters of deep personal meaning. This is a necessary precursor for you to do a “right action.”

What is your experience of the quiet space, the gap, in-between your thinking and your actions? Take a moment and feel it now.

Hei is a perfectly balanced letter and since our society is a predominately masculine culture, your choice of the letter Hei is very important. It means you are ready for more balance in your life.

Allowing the feminine principle into your life is crucial for the balance our society is yearning for. The Kabbalah teaches that Hashem gave women an additional measure of spiritual understanding than He gave to men. Now that you have chosen Hei, this understanding is available to you. Everyone’s nature includes universality, sensitivity, limitlessness, nurturing, and conservation of life.

Which feminine aspect of your nature is most important to you now? The first answer that arises no matter what you may think is the one to explore.

As well as being perfectly balanced, Hei is also a broken letter. You could be experiencing a broken relationship, a broken heart, or breaking away from a career or a job that no longer suits you. By choosing Hei, you have heard the whisper of the letter and need the nurturing, feminine, aspect of Hashem. It is time to become balanced in your life by being close to Hei.

The gap between thought and action is real. Although accessing that gap is valuable to your inner life, it can be uncomfortable. The Kabbalah teaches that Hashem put this gap in place so you could experience this dissonance, the choice between the real and the ideal, between thought and action.

As you move forward spiritually and emotionally, Hei provides you with the sensitivity to see your imperfections, challenges, and brokenness, while embracing them all with Hei’s harmony. By choosing to experience this gap between your thought and action, you give yourself this opportunity. The Kabbalah teaches that when we are active in this process of divine no-thingness, this gap, we become true partners with Hashem.

The number for Hei is five. Consequently, there are five steps between each thought and the action taken. They are:

1. having the idea
2. feeling the space
3. planning the execution
4. bridging to the higher self

5. acting from the highest good

The Kabbalah also teaches that the end of the action was the first in thought. This is a Kabbalistic Koan similar to the question, “**what** is the sound of one hand clapping?”

Do you know what is meant by the end of the action was the first in thought? Trace one of your past actions back to its original thought.

Do you hear your present thoughts waiting to be brought into action?

Do you know which of the five-steps you are comfortable with and which ones give you the most trouble and stress?

When you share your thoughts with others, you are revealing yourself. Although this intimacy can feel uncomfortable at first, when you get used to it, it brings you exquisite joy. When you give yourself to another, you are giving the ultimate gift. The ultimate gift is you. It takes the willingness to experience intimacy, (in-to-me-see) which may feel uncomfortable at first.

Shadow Aspect of Hei

- When you utter harsh words to another instead of first listening to your thoughts, you are demonstrating a shadow aspect of Hei. Rather than think through what you need to say, you ignore the gap and do not take ownership of your words and the meaning behind them. This can be devastating to all involved; words cannot be recalled after they are spoken. Spoken words are like feathers that come out of a pillow; it is impossible to gather them back once they are let loose.
- When we think that what we have to say is most important, we are directly in the shadow of Hei. In that moment we are so self-focused our idea becomes all that matters. That behavior psychically eliminates the other person from our thoughts, and our partnership with Hashem disappears.
- When we engage only one-step of the five-stage process, and ignore the other four, we eliminate our capability to live in that conscious gap provided by Hashem. We are then unable to express our authentic self. We behave like robots and shadows of our true self. We live as if on a treadmill, repeating our patterns over and over again.
- It is easy to be stuck in brokenness, whether from a relationship, the end of a career, or a loss. It can be dramatic, possibly even familiar and self-fulfilling,

but ultimately crippling. This shadow aspect of Hei calls to us like the legends of the sirens that call out to the sailors when they are lonely and desperate. Is brokenness an illusion or is it real?

Right Actions for Hei:

- Choose the feelings that come from right action. Remember that many of your thoughts are old patterns and thoughts think. Choose to do what bring you into the creative, feminine principle of Hei. They are the nurturing, compassionate, forgiving, inspired actions. When other negative, reactive thoughts appear, notice them, and move on. At one time, they were there to protect you. No longer receiving your attention, they will disappear over time.
- Write down the actions and experiences you choose to identify with at this time and focus on them each day. Notice what happens to your mood and perspective.
- When you feel fear in any form, such as anger, resentment or worry, remember, your actions are always a choice. Put yourself in that gap between thought and action. Choose an action that allows the fear to lose its power by sharing yourself, remembering a positive moment, and knowing that Hashem is never far away.
- Before you take action, move into the gap and experience the silence. The gap is the experience of the Divine. Be aware of the highest good in your action.



Rabbi Meir of Premishlan used to go to a Mikvah, a sacred, ritual bath in a river on a steep hill outside the city. He would make this trek even on icy, winter days. Once some skeptical young men tried to follow the old rabbi up the slippery hill, but they slipped and were so badly injured they needed medical treatment. After the young men were healed, one of them, somewhat humbled by the experience, dared to ask the venerable sage how he could climb day after day without falling. Rabbi Meir replied in a straightforward manner: 'If a person is connected above, he does not fall down below!'

VAV

Meaning: Hook, 'and' (a conjunction)

Focus: Connection or Link – represents completion.

Number: 6

Calendar Connection: Iyar: the second month of the Kabbalah year.
(April-May)

By choosing Vav, it means you are ready to connect to all the different aspects of yourself. Right now, you have the fortitude to let go of the power your past mistakes have over you, and transform your regrets into compassion.

Vav is the sixth letter of the Hebrew Alef-Bet and represents the sixth day of creation, the day right before Hashem rested. This is the day Hashem completed the creation of the universe. By choosing Vav, you are personally ready to take another step toward completion, which may include correcting actions from your past, making new choices in the present, and/or creating new visions for the future. It is time to take a clear look at yourself and take charge of your cycle of mistakes, judgment, and regret.

As you meditate on the shape of the Vav, you can see that it is facing forward to the future while staying grounded in the present. Look at the letter now. Remember, Hebrew letters read from right to left.

As you meditate on the Vav, what do you think it means to face the future while staying grounded?

What future vision arose for you from this meditation?

What action do you need to take to ground this vision?

There are some interesting aspects to Vav, as you understand that the Biblical Hebrew meaning means Hook and Connection.

- As a prefix to a noun, Vav means “and,” so it clearly connects what came before to what follows.
- As a prefix to a verb, it changes the tense of the verb from past to future or from future to past giving it transformative powers.
- Vav has the ability to move backward or forward in time with great power to help heal the past and envision the future.

The energy of Vav connects and brings opposites together. For example, past and future, negative and positive, fear and joy. When you remember that Hashem created the universe from these Hebrew letters, you begin to understand that Vav has the power to support you in “teshuvah,” meaning repentance and

transformation. You do “teshuvah” by turning away from fear and negativity, by facing forward to personal purpose and meaning, to “tikkun,” repair of the world.

How is this important to you now?

The Kabbalah teaches when Hashem created the universe he sent a single ray of light to our world. When this light entered our world, it was so immense and radiant, there was a shattering, and the light scattered. You can get a glimpse of what this might have looked like when walking in the woods and seeing rays of light filtering through the trees.

The Kabbalah continues by saying Hashem then entered into a partnership with us to repair this shattering. Our commitment in this partnership is to bring all the sparks or particles of light back to Hashem so together we can create a righteous planet. We can use our free will to help heal that brokenness in the behavior we choose from moment to moment. Because of this partnership, we sometimes feel our true home is beyond where we stand. We have all heard people speak of wanting to go home to Hashem when they are ill. By choosing Vav, you have found the courage to stay.

When you bring light and consciousness to your past actions, you can forgive yourself and repair the world. By transforming that darkness from your past, you can change your future.

Think of some incident from your past. Just for a moment, see it as healed. What changes need to occur to make this real?

This takes courage. When you do this with positive intention, you have decided to whisper the ineffable name of Hashem into the tapestry of your life.

The Shadow Aspect of Vav:

- Many people at this time in our history tend to be stuck in the “light.” They do not want the experience of just what is. Instead, they judge it or see it as negative, or project it on others in the form of judgment, racism, sexism, etc. They do not want to associate with this aspect of life. However, Vav depends on what is to first heal and then to help in the reconstruction of the earth. What a paradox. We need our dark side to create wholeness.
- Vav means connection or hook. A connection can be good or bad. We can be connected to Hashem or we can be hooked on almost anything. This can be a relationship, a drug, and a way of thinking. A shadow aspect of Vav is this addiction or hook to those things that keep us from our connection to Hashem.

- When you observe an unhealthy connection between people, such as one following the other's path, you may have the experience that the two people are not individuated. This over identification is another shadow aspect of Vav.

Right Actions for Vav:

Because Vav links with words to make connections, you need to use words to reconnect your heart with those you love.

- Have conversations you have avoided with those close to you. Now is a good time for repair.
- Remember a time that you blamed another for your own results. Find that person and discuss this with them. Let them know that you are aware of what you did.
- Look at an incident or a relationship you have not wanted to resolve or complete. Take an action in this situation. Allow your heart to speak. Vulnerability is pure strength.
- Since we only experience feeling lost when we have disconnected from Hashem, offer your hand to create a connection with someone in need, someone who might feel lost. Also, accept support from another when you feel lost or need help. Allow Vav to assist you in this right action.



There is a teaching from Rabbi Michele from the city of Zelitchov, a disciple of the Baal Shem Tov. He said when you listen to someone's prayers and hear what they ask for; many times you hear cries for more and more money. In fact, it is often difficult to hear anything else. However, when you squeeze out the inner intentions of those sincere prayers, you get Mitzvot which mean commandments. In other words, the sincere and true desire of the soul for material wealth is to be able to do more good in the world and follow Hashem's commandments.

Zayin

Meaning: Sword, woman of valor

Focus: Activity and rest, balance and sustainability

Number: 7

Calendar Connection: Sivan -- May-June

When you choose Zayin, it means you are capable of accepting paradox as your way of life. The contradictions life tends to bring to our attention are now within your understanding. You are being asked to assess your current life situation with a saber-like precision. You can expect to experience opposing perspectives in yourself and in the world while maintaining balance. These perspectives co-exist as different aspects of reality. You have the choice to see these opposites as a challenge and a gift of grace or as a burden and a problem.

What contradictions are present in your thinking at this time?

How do these contradictions affect your spiritual journey?

Zayin means sword or weapon. Its spiritual meaning is a “woman of valor”, a bride, and a weapon of Spirit who brings elevated consciousness and sustenance to her marriage. This marriage is the merging of the male and female consciousness within us. The Kabbalah teaches that each of us has this “woman of valor” within whether we are male or female. The Baal Shem Tov taught that Zayin refers to woman because of a verse in proverbs that reads, “A woman of valor is the crown of her husband.”

The letter Zayin represents this concept in its shape and form. This feminine aspect of Zayin has the power to reveal to the masculine sword-like aspect of Zayin, an innate experience of tranquility and resolve. According to the Kabbalah, this same experience always occurs during the Sabbath, the 7th day of the Kabbalistic week. These two meanings represent the co-existence of paradox in Zayin.

Do you have a connection with your internal “Woman of Valor?”

Do you have difficulty holding this paradox of androgyny?

Zayin also stands for Zikaron or memory. According to the Kabbalah, while we are in the womb, we learn and integrate all the secrets of the universe. At our moment of birth, an angel pinches our upper lip between our nose and mouth, and thus we forget what we have learned while preparing for birth. It then becomes our life work to remember the truth we knew before we were born. The word time (*zman*) in Hebrew begins with Zayin; as does the word remember (*zachor*) and remembrance (*zikaron*). The memory of that time before we were born is the basis for our self-identity and our purpose in Hashem’s creation. We have that memory within us and if we choose to, we can access it.

Do you remember what you chose for your life work?

The numerical value of Zayan is 7.

- Shabbat is the seventh day of the week
- There are 7 days of the week
- Seven is considered a beloved number

The Kabbalah teaches that Hashem created the universe in 6 days and rested on the 7th. Like Hashem we rest on the seventh day of each week. This is a gift from Hashem not to be refused. It is a day to remember our purpose here on earth. We receive an extra measure of our soul on this day of rest. This is the part of our soul that remains dormant all week while we attend to life's tasks. While we are active, it is difficult to experience this aspect of our soul. During Shabbat, or this seventh day of rest, you meet yourself and this extra measure of your soul is with you.

What does it mean to fully rest?

According to the Kabbalah, humans struggle with life's challenges in the sword-like, masculine, physical world all week long. Hashem gives you this seventh day to receive the feminine and contemplate His gift of peace and reflection. This is a time to pray, to sing, to walk, and to play in nature. By creating sacred time on this seventh day, you are able to bring the energy of the Sabbath to the rest of your week. You can marry the masculine energy of the workweek with the feminine energy of the Sabbath. Remember, Zayin is the sign of a sword, a weapon, and a symbol of the peace of Shabbat, the bride of the Sabbath. This represents the paradox of Zayin.

How do you enjoy the feminine aspect of your soul and the masculine aspect of the physical world?

When you allow yourself to enjoy the pursuit of spiritual endeavors, you experience your longing for greater depth in life. You can then bring this consciousness and knowledge to the physical plane. You are a spiritual warrior filled with the freedom of the revelations received on Shabbat.

Shadow Aspects of Zayin:

- The Sabbath is a day of rest in many religions. However, over indulging in rest, food, material wealth, and all other luxuries of life is a shadow aspect of Zayin. It is easy to become spiritually lazy and forget why you are here.
- Inappropriate aggression and maintaining a war-like consciousness is another shadow aspect of Zayin. The opposite of a spiritual warrior is a

power hungry fighter, one who sees and seizes negativity everywhere. This leads to perverting the transformative powers of Zayin - to control others and experience fear in the world.

- Keeping busy without allowing unstructured space and rest is also a shadow aspect of Zayin. The busyness of life without an appreciation of the beingness of life eliminates the potentials inherent in Zayin and leads to becoming spiritually bereft and desolate. This overwork mentality without the time to reflect keeps Hashem from permeating your consciousness.

Right Actions for Zayin

Zayin is regarded as the generating and ruling principle over universal movement. In this movement you learn to control life's opposites by function of your will.

- During Shabbat, rest and meditate while acknowledging you may have the desire to solve a problem, or be busy.
- After Shabbat, bring Hashem into the rest of your week as a partner. Sustain the connection and bring balance to your workweek.
- Do what is right in an important situation. Decide if it is time to act or to wait. This is the action that will test your partnership with Hashem.
- Pray or meditate on your Sabbath day. What you experience during that time is especially for you. If an inspiration for action comes, take that action after Shabbat.
- Spend time with your family and friends without an agenda.
- Use incisiveness, clarity of mind and intention to safeguard what is precious to you.



In the Hebrew Bible, we read that when Pharaoh's daughter came to bathe in the Nile she spotted a basket holding a baby. When she realized it was a Hebrew baby, she knew she had to make a quick decision. Should she obey her father's decree that all Hebrew babies should be drowned, or should she defy her father and everything he taught her so she could save the baby? The Bible states in Hebrew, that she "sent her hand maidens to save the baby." These words can also mean she personally stretched her arm out to reach the basket. The sages tell us that even though her arm was unable to reach that far through natural

means, a miracle occurred and her hand was able to extend beyond its natural capacity.

CHET

MEANING: Life and Fear

FOCUS: Gateway to infinity

NUMBER: 8

CALENDAR CONNECTION: Tamuz – June/July

When you choose Chet, it means you are ready to let go of self-limiting perceptions and open yourself to a more expansive life. Because Chet means both life and fear, these perceptions can be both positive and negative. Many of our life experiences are multifaceted. They are life giving, passionate, and fearful all at the same time. Falling in love, climbing a Peruvian mountain, and committing to a spiritual life are just some examples that fit these criteria.

What in your experience is both life giving and fearful?

The Kabbalah teaches that when you see yourself and this world without your ego filters or self-limiting perceptions, you experience awe. This can be fearful. Three things can happen; you become aware of the preciousness of life, you accept the infinite our life represents, and you confront your fear with wisdom and respect.

When are you in awe of life?

The shape of the letter Chet combines both masculine and feminine Hebrew letters. When connected, the energies and form of these letters create Chet. This connection resembles a roof, a bridge, or even a bridal canopy called a Chuppa. This canopy connecting masculine and feminine energies stands for Hashem or the infinite. By choosing this letter, you are ready to include Hashem as the third presence, the connecting force in your relationships.

The Kabbalah teaches that we have within us a potential balance of masculine and feminine energy. Our choice of an intimate partner is influenced by what we lack in either of these energies. Our attraction to a partner is based on what we believe we are missing, whether we are conscious of it or not. However, after initial attraction lessens and we are no longer seeing through rose-colored glasses, our perceptions shift and we tend to judge what we were once enamored by. It is only when we let go of our judgments that we accept Hashem into our relationships. Sages have said that to initiate a relationship between a man and a woman is relatively easy, but to maintain it is miraculous, even for Hashem.

What relationships in your life are calling out for this masculine-feminine balance?

How can including Hashem in your relationships support you?

Choosing Chet at this time helps you to have the courage to peel and uncover the veils and skins of this world to receive Hashem in a deeper more intimate way. This experience can be an emotional time in your journey. It can bring forth many past fears and tears. With Chet, you need to walk along this emotional and spiritual edge of life and fear. Chet calls us to walk this way with compassion

What spiritual edge awaits you?

What does this mean to you?

The Kabbalah teaches that Chet transcends nature by bringing life to the dead. This means it is possible to resurrect the dreams and ideals you have given up for dead. Many tend to forget their dreams as they choose a more practical solution to their life questions. Yet, their dreams do not really die. They are just waiting for the opportunity to be brought to life again in a new way. With Hashem as your partner, it is now your time to resurrect your dreams.

The number for Chet is eight.

- The sign for infinity is a sideways “8”.
- There are eight days of Chanukah, Passover, and Sukkot

What does it mean for you to choose a letter that symbolizes the gateway to Infinity, a letter that goes beyond nature?

The Kabbalah says that during Chanukah, it is possible to go beyond nature and experience a miracle. A miracle can best be described as a **victory against overwhelming odds**. This is what happened to create the holiday of Chanukah. There was a military victory that went against all odds, and the oil that should have lasted one day stayed lit for eight.

Chet brings the lights of chaos into the vessels of order. This means take a risk. This means experience the unknown, while staying connected to Hashem. The Kabbalah teaches that the energy of the Chet has to do with Hashem “hovering” over the world. When Hashem hovers over his created world, He is continuing to sustain and nourish His world while at the same time allowing all the creatures in this world to live independently. When you choose Chet, you are about to do the same. You have chosen to defy the gravity of your personal world and leap into the chaos

of spiritual joy. This is not an easy task. Although you may feel afraid at times, you are ready.

Shadow Aspects of Chet:

- Walking through the emotional and spiritual edge of life and fear can create a form of paralysis or behavior that is thoughtless or dangerous. Both of these extremes are equal in their creation of repetitive negativity. This shadow aspect of Chet can be insidious and challenging unless fears are made an ally.
- Staying in our comfort zone and acting out of a spiritually costumed self-interest is another shadow aspect of Chet. Many people pretend they are living life fully and have accepted fear as a friend and ally, while in reality they have not.
- Chet's shadow blames Hashem when life is difficult. This shadow aspect of Chet also denies the possibility to accept personal responsibility for mistakes.

Right Actions for Chet:

- Look for places in your life where you are resting in your comfort zones. Pick one to explore. Take an action that has an "awesome" risk to it.
- The next time you make a mistake, tell eight people, the number for Chet without making excuses or blaming anyone, including yourself.
- Share from your heart and allow yourself to feel the fear intimacy demands. As you make this fear your ally, you will allow more intimacy into your relationships.



Reb Shlomo Carlebach, asked, " Do you know how the BAL Sham Tov defined Heaven and Hell " He then continued," After a thousand years all of us go up to heaven for the heavenly court. There they show us

two movies. One movie depicts how we were in life and the other what we could have been. If the two movies match, that is heaven. But, if they are not alike, that is hell."

Tet

Meaning: Womb and Serpent

Focus: Concealed good

Number: 9

Calendar Connection: Month of Av

When you choose Tet, it means you are in the state of "becoming" true to yourself. Hashem has held you closely, in a place of "goodness" and the incubation stage is complete. You can now emerge from the womb of becoming, to the world of being, to shed that which no longer serves your goals and desires.

What aspect of your history does not serve you now?

How has your goodness been incubating?

Tet is the first letter of the word beauty in the Hebrew language and also one of the eight synonyms for the word beauty. Tet also is the first letter of the word Tov, meaning "good." Tet refers to the level of beauty bathed in modesty --the ability of beauty to be partially concealed and introverted during its gestation period.

How does your beauty and modesty show up in the world?

The Kabbalah teaches the hidden goodness in Tet is needed to bring together heaven and earth, to reveal inner light and to understand the deepest reason for creation. This can now happen for you as you take the time to "be in the world yet not of the world."

What does this mean to you?

By focusing on that which is good inside you and feeding your feelings of goodness, you will discover the direct path to your freedom.

The number for Tet is nine.

- nine months of pregnancy
- nine positive mitzvot (blessings) in the creation of character

- numerical symbols of truth and eternity

Because Tet is a feminine letter, many see it as a snake coiled in on itself. Before the snake became associated with negativity, it was a symbol of the Divine feminine nature as well as the shape of another letter Samech. Snakes shed their skin regularly.

What aspects of your life have you outgrown and can now shed?

Shadow aspects of Tet:

- Staying fixed “in potential” rather than taking risks is a shadow aspect of Tet. People spend their life in their potential and refuse to take the risks needed to test their possibilities.
- It is commonplace for one to stick their head in the sand and believe they are seeing from an enlightened space. This occurs because Tet can create the illusion you are fulfilled, and your relationship with Hashem is exclusive. This supports a feeling of superiority and eventually isolation and retreat from this world.
- Blaming yourself or others for illness, an accident, or misfortunes because of negative thinking, is another shadow aspect of Tet. Hiding pain and suffering, using the excuse that Hashem must have wanted it this way is irresponsible thinking. This leads to a religiously incorrect victim mentality that is very difficult to let go of.

Right Actions

- Find the goodness in the darkest part of your personality.
- Actualize your potential. Take an action that will change a life situation. Watch your response as the results play themselves out.
- Set time aside each day for prayer. Allow Hashem to play an active role through the Mitzvah of prayer.
- Shed an old skin. Take your time and do this quietly without fanfare or apology.



Once, a Rabbi walked into a synagogue. Seeing that no one else was there, he opened the Holy Ark and began to plead. "Hashem, I am

like Abraham who said, I am only dust and ashes. I am nothing and a nobody." A few minutes later, the Cantor walked in and walked up to the ark on the other side of the Rabbi. He began to berate himself in the presence of the Holy Ark declaring that he's a nothing and lower than an insect on the earth. A few minutes later the custodian walked in, pushed his way between the Rabbi and the Cantor, started copying them, and said, Hashem I am a nobody and a nothing in your eyes." The Rabbi moved over to the Cantor and elbowed him and they both pointed to the custodian and said, "Look who also thinks he's a nobody."

YUD

Meaning: The Hand and Power

Focus: Revealed Good

Number: 10

Calendar Connection: Elul – August/September

When you choose Yud, it means you are capable of knowing the human equivalent of Divine thought. You can now choose to experience the force of immediate transformation rather than the ease of incremental change. This may seem foreign to you as we are taught that change takes time.

You are a spiritual seeker ready to move through barriers of great force. To do this you need humility. It is important to remember that you are in partnership with Hashem, that your accomplishments are not entirely your own. This may be difficult to digest. Yet with the power of Yud in your hand, it can be easier than you think.

What have you taken full credit for, without acknowledging your partnership with Hashem?

The Kabbalah teaches that creation began with Yud. In addition, every letter in the Hebrew Alef-Bet begins with Yud. It is the DNA of the DNA. Because it is so small and so quick in movement, it is the first point of entry from the infinite and eternal world of Hashem into the finite world of humans. Even though small is size, it creates the future tense of verbs and the opportunity of future transformation for humans. This means it is a letter of action, movement, and depth.

The Kabbalah also teaches that the Yud shed its ego before Hashem made it the point of creation. Although we are unable to shed our egos, we also have a point of the infinite and eternal. It occurs when the egg and sperm connect and we create life. This momentous act reflects the power of Yud. It also occurs when we write a

poem, create a piece of art, dance for no reason, offer a prayer in the forest, cook a delicious meal without a recipe, and when we experience Hashem.

What is your deepest, innermost point of connection to Hashem? How do you experience it?

You have decided to transform, shedding some of your history. The Kabbalah says that creation is a continuous process of renewal that begins from “no -thing.” This concept goes hand in hand with your choice of the Yud. The same transformation you are going through now began before you were born. It began with Hashem’s creation of the Yud.

Can you be still enough to receive the power of Yud?

Can you use this innate power to see who and what you really are?

Remember, Yud represents that intersection, that moment when non-existence becomes existence.

Can you remember a time when you had an idea that seemingly came out of nowhere? What happened to it? Could Yud have powered that?

By giving up attempt to change the world around you for your comfort and focusing instead on responding with right action to your environment, you will stay centered as you walk the path of Yud.

How can you do this? Do any ideas immediately come to mind?

The number for Yud is 10.

- The Kabbalah teaches that 10 people are needed to pray together to connect with the essence of Hashem.
- There are 10 commandments
- Ten is the basis for the numerical system

Once you enter the energy pattern of Yud, you look deeper into the world around you. It becomes difficult to make quick judgments of people or situations as you know that everyone is in flux and moving at their unique pace. You can see the divinity of life situations by being with what is. This means seeing all events around you for what they are rather than trying to change them to your own liking.

What personal transformation do you want to achieve?

Are you ready to enter into a partnership with Hashem?

Remember, Yud means hand. Are you opening your hands to Hashem?

The Shadow Aspect of Yud:

When you rush into the radical transformation needed to do the work that Yud calls for without being prepared for the chaos that follows, there can be many repercussions. Your thinking gets confused. You can feel uprooted and out of balance. Your relationships suffer, seemingly losing their significance. This can happen even though relationships are more important to you now than before.

Self-deprecation under the guise of modesty or humility is another shadow aspect of Yud. It is false and pretentious. If you go down a transformational road in this way, you will fall into an abyss, unable to stay on the path and hold your ground. This can lead you into a state of depression and deep regret.

We have been taught that power means control, either of ourselves or of others. Of course, there are times when we need to control ourselves and see value in controlling another. However, this shadow side of Yud's power, this false humility, occurs when we do not stand up for our personal beliefs and values. This also occurs when we forget that the hand of Hashem created all species as well as the earth herself. We do not control the outcome. This shadow power creates violence and despair.

Right Actions for Yud:

- Be intimate with yourself. Tell yourself the truth. Allow others to see your innermost point of existence — the Yud inside of you.
- See that innermost point in others. When this occurs, you create a moment when the world is transformed. If you continue to see, the transformation you are seeking will become natural.
- From a place of In-to-me-see, discover those truths about yourself that you may not have wanted to see in the past.
- As you transform your life, the essential you will not change. You will simply shed aspects of your personality that no longer serve you. While in the process, keep your good humor and your compassion. This is often forgotten in the midst of transformation. Humor and compassion help to ease the transition.

- Remember that everyone is unique. Everyone's transformation occurs when they are ready. Listen and see those around you as they are; not as you think they should be.



The Hebrew Bible says that when the Israelites were on the border of the land of Israel, they asked Moses to send spies to check out the land.

Twelve spies were chosen, one from each of the twelve tribes. When they entered the land, they found people dying all around them. There were also giant size people, fruit and vegetables. When the spies came back, ten of the twelve reported the land as impossible to enter and said, "Everything is too large to conquer and the land eats up and consumes its inhabitants." They could have taken a different perspective and said, "What a wonderful land. How large the fruits are. There are many funerals going on and so our presence in this land is undetected and Hashem is paving the way for us to enter safely. "

Kaf

Meaning: Palm and Crown

Focus: Shaping your reality, influencing the shaping of the universe

Number: 20

Calendar Connection: Wednesday – 4th day of the week

When you choose Kaf, you are poised for a "crowning" achievement. At this time your will and your ability to focus are capable of laser-like precision. It is a time to let go of thinking about your deep desires, and to form your desires into reality. Because Kaf is a sign of true majesty as well as a home for the feminine aspect of Hashem, it can be experienced as the connector of the spiritual and the material worlds. It connects spirit and matter. It allows your dreams to become real.

What realized dream do you call your "crowning achievement?"

The Kabbalah teaches that the letter Kaf adds strength to your intention in sacred acts and deep prayer. The aspect of intention expressed in the letter Kaf is similar to Hashem's intention. Hashem continuously creates the world. His potential is always being actualized. We have this same potential. We often forget we are spark of the divine.

How is your intention aligned with Hashem's?

In our fairy tales and myths, we carry an archetypical picture of the king or wise man or woman putting their palm on our head to bless us. Kaf, fulfills that archetypical aspect by helping you create your crowning achievement. People of many different religions express Kaf by wearing head coverings.

How do you express your wisdom in the world?

According to the Kabbalah, Hashem continuously creates the world. Otherwise creation would instantaneously vanish. His potential is actualized at each moment. Your desire and your will have power to transform your intellect. This is similar to a human king who has the power to manifest his desire upon the land, and certainly to the King of Kings, Hashem, as he continuously creates the world.

Shadow Aspects of Kaf

- Many times people allow their material security and ego need take precedence over their true desires. This shadow aspect of Kaf takes many forms and makes “rational sense” when active.
- When people act as if they are King or Queen, they are manifesting the shadow aspect of Kaf. They can become a despot to those around them and trick themselves into believing they are being righteous.
- Manipulation of the self as well as others creates a devious arrogance, which is also a shadow aspect of Kaf. It has all the telltale signs of self-righteousness.

Right Actions for Kaf

- Make a list of the “crowning achievements” you want to accomplish over the next few years. Take steps to create these “crowning achievements” in accordance with your deepest and highest values. Match your intention with the thought and prayer, “Not my will, but Thy will be done.”
- Ask for feedback about your past behavior from a trusted friend or advisor who shares similar values as yours, and who is unafraid to tell you what they think.
- When you take action, make sure you are doing so with the dignity that your highest values demand. For example, do not embarrass anyone along the way. Make sure that you give credit where credit is due.



King Solomon began his rule when he was only 12 years old. Hashem came to him in a dream and offered him a choice of wealth, a long life, or wisdom. Solomon chose wisdom and asked for a heart that hears truth. When he woke up, the young King found that he was indeed able to converse with all living creatures and even with plants.

LAMED

Meaning: To learn and to teach, a prod for guiding oxen or cattle

Focus: Guided movement, accomplishing goals

Number: 30

Calendar Connection: Tishrei - October/Nov

When you choose Lamed it means you are open to the wisdom of your heart and can allow it to prod you forward in your quest for freedom. You are nimble enough to climb spiritual heights while wise enough to learn how to use your gifts of guidance. The limits you believed held you back in the past are now prodding you forward. You have freed up the shadow energy you've used before to judge and project on others. You are now reclaiming your inherent passion for learning and sharing. With this aspect of your personality freed up, you can now allow your heart to guide you

How do you influence others?

Please observe both the positive and the negative aspects of your influence. The Kabbalah and eastern practices teach that once you exert influence on another, you must assume a measure of responsibility for that person.

How do you hold yourself back?

Are you willing to see it is not others who hold you back?

The number for Lamed is 30.

Lamed is the letter of guidance and teaching. It is the tallest, most crooked letter in the Hebrew Alef-Bet. It mirrors our path in life; our path to wisdom is neither direct nor straight. We travel a winding road. Each time we turn a corner on that road we need to trust that Hashem is guiding us. On the first flight to the moon there were over 6,000 corrections needed for the astronauts to arrive there safely.

The size and shape of Lamed reflects its connection to the higher world of Hashem and the lower world of humans. You need to be congruent to come from your heart, and allow your inner desires to guide your outer creation. When your uniqueness and talent are working together, your heart will recognize your goal and the learning you need to reach it. Then you commit with all your might. Choosing this letter supports you to learn to use your power and wisdom wisely,

With whom can you share your wisdom?

Are you open to learning from others? Can you allow another to share their wisdom with you?

What are your natural talents and inner desires?

In many cultures, Adam, or masculine consciousness is viewed as the mind and Eve, the symbol for feminine consciousness, is viewed as the heart. This marriage of the mind and the heart create the passion and thinking that allow you to accomplish the spiritual heights that Lamed represents.

Shadow Aspect of Lamed:

- When the intellect is more important than the natural world, our knowledge is dry and self-serving. This is a shadow aspect of Lamed. When this shadow process occurs, you may lose your sense of clarity, forget your vision, and become exhausted both physically and emotionally. Driven in this direction, you can become a disembodied intellect.
- When you have grand ideas lacking the skills or talents to carry them through, you are demonstrating another shadow aspect of Lamed. This occurs when you allow your ego needs to overpower your relationships and you behave as if you are more important. You become “like a tower in the sky” without the necessary foundation to hold it up.
- When you won’t choose to learn and create from your heart, you stay in a state of uncertainty. This is another shadow aspect of Lamed. As Thoreau stated so brilliantly, you live a life “of quiet desperation.” When in this state, you recreate old patterns of negativity.

Right Action for Lamed:

- Most people regret what they did not do, rather than what mistakes they made. Choose to learn something for which you have great passion. Share what you learn with those around you through who you are, not by lecturing. This is a way to teach and learn simultaneously.
- As you return to your own power and your wisdom, experience the changes in how you perceive yourself. Look at your surroundings, your clothing, your furnishings, your work, your friends and your family. Make the changes to reflect who you have become.
- Allow yourself to receive compliments from people close to you and refrain from explaining or justifying. How does this change the way you see yourself?



One day the Baal Shem Tov met a water carrier, an old man, bent over carrying his pails of water. He asked him, "How are you doing?" The man answered with a groan and a sigh and said, "I'm in my 80's and I still have to carry around these buckets of water. How do you think I am doing?" The following day, the Baal Shem Tov saw the same man carrying his water with a lighter step, his shoulders raised. Again, he asked him, "How are you doing today?" And the old man replied, "Thank Hashem, even though I'm in my 80's, I still have work to do, I still have water to carry, and I still have the shoulders to carry this water and benefit the people. "

MEM

Meaning: Water/Womb

Focus: Purification

Number: 40/mother letter

Calendar Connection: Winter

When you choose Mem, it is time to flow like water become unstuck. It is now your time to heal and flow through the river of change. You may be holding on to old grief or sorrow. The emotions you have held back and allowed to harden are coming loose. Grief and sorrow harden over time and look like anger or other negative emotions. It is your time to move. Time is like a river that flows downstream, once the water has passed, it is gone. Your opportunity is NOW. You are ready to birth yourself and become your own parent: one who is loving and kind, with clear boundaries.

What old emotions are you holding ?

What opportunity is present for you to let go of?

Mem is the symbol for water as well as womb. Our bodies are mostly water and throughout time, water has stood for life's flow, weightlessness and purification.

In numerous religions, water is a symbol for renewal and rebirth. The Kabbalah teaches that when we unfreeze from a frozen position into a fluid one, we become an agent of purification. This flow is a source of wisdom.

What frozen position has been a source of pain for you?

Mem is the thirteenth letter of the Alef-Bet. The Kabbalah teaches that there are thirteen available open channels in each of us for Hashem to enter our consciousness. These channels are the pathways through which the wisdom of Mem can flow. These channels are the 13 attributes of compassion and mercy.

How can compassion grow inside of you?

The number for Mem is 40.

- The great flood lasted 40 days and 40 nights
- Moses and the Hebrew slaves spent 40 years in the desert
- Each time Moses went up Mt. Sinai, he was there for 40 days and 40 nights
- The embryo is formed after 40 days

Shadow aspects of Mem:

- Many people allow their emotions to capture their heart and mind. They are unable to function productively. They wallow in their sea of emotions without allowing the current to carry them to shore, to dry land. This wallowing is a shadow aspect of Mem capable of drowning one.
- Sorrow and anger are seductive ways of controlling others. A shadow aspect of Mem is hanging on to pain and seeing the self as a victim. This victimization allows for behaviors that otherwise would not be tolerated by others.
- Living in the stream of unconsciousness is also a shadow aspect of Mem.
- Attributing our limitations to our parents is yet another shadow aspect of Mem. Remember, Mem is a mother letter in Alef-Bet and our internal experience of “mother” affects our relationship with the world and can enslave us.

Right Actions for Mem:

- Put yourself in the position of experiencing a difficult emotion. It could be any emotion. Some of the most difficult emotions are, anger, neediness,

embarrassment, fear, and love. Experience your choice fully and watch how this emotion transforms.

- Choose an environment that you control where you would rather experience flow. Allow yourself to move forward with genuine desire for freedom.
- Choose to appreciate and be grateful for all aspects of life. Open yourself like a vessel to receive blessings. Be a channel for Hashem. Tears may come and wash away toxic particles blocking your freedom and flow.



According to the story of the prophet Jonah and the whale, Jonah was thrown into the water because he tried to run away from Hashem. Instead of listening to Hashem, he decided to follow his desire and go to the city of Nineveh by ship. Hashem created a huge storm to threaten the safety of the ship. In order to jolt him from his disregard for Hashem's directive, he was thrown into the water. It was only then the storm abated. The sages relate that when Jonah entered the water, a male whale swallowed him. While inside this male whale, he felt quite dry and comfortable, and once again did not listen to Hashem. Hashem then tickled the nose of the male whale and Jonah was sneezed into the mouth and belly of a pregnant female whale. When this occurred, Jonah became quite uncomfortable, and in his stress, realized he could not return to his old life. His true purpose took over his life from this point on.

Nun

Meaning: Fish

Focus: Falling back in place

Number: 50

Calendar Connection: Cheshvan – October/November

When you choose Nun, it means you have fallen away from yourself and your escape route to your old ways seems closed. Only Hashem can help you return to your true self. You may believe your self-imposed limitations are permanent. They are not. You may think many external limitations are real. They are not. Choosing Nun presents you with the opportunity to shift how you experience your fears and your view of the world. In order to take advantage of this opportunity, you need to use your spiritual and emotional maturity and live in paradox. This means you need to match your desire for freedom with a simultaneous focus on self-discipline.

What self-imposed limitations have you believed were permanent?

What desires have you squelched?

In the past, you may not have taken full responsibility for your choices. If you remember the story of Jonah, once your discomfort is stronger than complacency, there is no way to return to your old life. As Jonah was in the belly of a whale, you have been in the belly of your own whale. When you surface from the belly of the world as you have known it, you will be transformed. The people and situations in your life will feel different. You have outgrown your old life and your choices will be made from this new perspective.

What choices have you made that were not in accord with your deepest knowing?

The Kabbalah teaches that the higher self can be a vessel to bring the word of Hashem into every action. Nun represents the humility of “not knowing.” Choosing Nun forces you to give up self-consciousness and become self-aware. The Kabbalah prescribes living in the mundane, every day world of the physical as a way to bring this light of Hashem into being.

In what ways have you been critical of your “mundane” life-style?

Nun is the 14th letter of the Alef-Bet and its number 50 equals the name of King David through the numerology of the Alef-Bet. According to the Kabbalah, King David is the source of the liberation and freedom of our world.

The number for Nun is 50.

- 50 gates of understanding

Shadow aspect of Nun:

- Thinking can be addictive if not tempered with wisdom. This shadow aspect of Nun can be hard, cold and brittle. In fact, it is a retreat from Hashem’s gift of true knowledge. When this addiction to the mind occurs, it needs to be treated similarly as one treats drugs or alcohol.
- Another shadow aspect of Nun is elusiveness and covert behavior. Sometimes people are only in relationship with their own thinking and needs rather than be with another. The opposite of freedom is not always being in chains. It can create distance from others and result in solitary, repetitive thinking.

- Maintaining the status quo when the higher self is calling for freedom is also a shadow aspect of Nun. There are always “right” reasons not to risk change. Pay no attention to them. With Nun, these “right” reasons bring heartache.

Right Actions for Nun:

- Own up to your personal truth. The speediest road to freedom and liberation from both external and self-imposed limitations is to speak and live your own truth. Share a truth you have been keeping inside. Live it..
- Ask Hashem for compassion and forgiveness. This action will melt the walls you have used for protection.
- Make a desired change. Give up your self –limiting reasons for avoiding making this change.



Hashem commanded Abraham to bring his son Isaac to the mountain as an offering. From Abraham's point of view, there were only two possibilities, neither of which was very pleasant or tenable. One option was to obey Hashem and sacrifice his only son and the other was to let his son live and disobey Hashem. He decided to obey Hashem. Some of the Rabbis point out this was when Abraham had a leap of faith. He realized that when his will is aligned with Hashem's he would attain a higher consciousness. He would see a third option allowing him to transcend the other two that were untenable. When Abraham was ready to bring Isaac to Hashem as an offering, an angel commanded him to keep Isaac alive. A ram then appeared out of nowhere to take the place of Isaac.

Samech

Meaning: Support, assistance

Focus: Finding the safety and trust to surrender

Number: 60

Calendar Connection: Kislev – November/December

When you choose Samech, you are ready to surrender to your infinite pool of strength and support. Until now, you have not been fully aware of the power within you. Because of this, you have been unaware of your effect on others. This may show itself in your desire to force your will upon another. Before now, you did not find it easy to trust in a higher power. This made you cautious in your relationships. The Kabbalah teaches that when you can trust in Hashem to support you, the power and authority of His support will make itself known.

How have you forced your will on others?

You may have had reasons in the past to keep your self-unseen from public view, hiding both your need for support and your need to give. However, by choosing Samech, the time has come for you to welcome support from others and to share yourself fully.

When have you kept yourself hidden from public view?

Samech is the letter that starts you on your path to interdependence. This state of being provides you with the opportunity to be both dependent and independent at the same time like the tress in a Redwood forest. Each tree in the forest has very short roots, yet grows very tall. Their roots are connected underground which gives them extraordinary strength. If the trees did not support each other through their root connection, they would fall over. This balance between dependence and independence can be likened to walking a spiritual tightrope.

Do you attempt to encourage others to be dependent on you? Do others force their will on you? How does this work?

Where are you on the continuum of dependence, independence and interdependence?

Samech is also a sign of Divine protection. Its shape is circular and reflects the spiritual belief of life having no beginning and no end. It symbolizes belief in the infinite. When we can trust this, we can surrender the illusion that we are alone. Choosing Samech means you are ready to let go of this illusion and know you have a spark of Hashem within — you are connected to the infinite.

When Moses climbed Mt. Sinai to receive the Ten Commandments, Samech was the one letter that bore through the tablets and did not fall out or leave a hole. The Kabbalah calls that miracle a demonstration of Hashem providing Divine protection with this sacred letter. You are always in the circle of that Divine protection. You trust it every night when you sleep. In order to sleep, you relax control. Although you are never sure you will awaken, you sleep.

Have you experienced insomnia? What was going on during that time?

Do you have trust in Divine protection? How do you express it?
How are these questions connected?

Samech supports us in defining our real boundaries as opposed to those we create out of our fear of surrender. Our real boundaries are those that give us enough space to fulfill our work here on earth.

The shape of Samech reminds us that the beginning is always embedded in the ending. It is the shape of the snake swallowing its own tail. It is the shape of the marriage ring, a hug, and the shape small children make automatically when they sit on the floor to play.

We all fear change. We fear the end of relationships, losing a job, or having our children leave home. We forget within every ending there is the beginning of something. We forget that fear of the future takes us away from the present moment, the place where we connect with Hashem. Your ability to surrender to the reality of your life allows you to experience Hashem protecting you through transitions.

The number for Samech is 60

- The number 6 stands for the communicator - the number 60 means communication at a higher level of connection
- Dreams are one-sixtieth of prophesy
- Shabbat is one-sixtieth of heaven or the world to come
- Fire is one-sixtieth of hell
- Honey is one-sixtieth of manna
- Sleep is one-sixtieth of death

Shadow aspect of Samech

- Behaving as if we do not need help or support and behaving as if we cannot do anything on our own are both shadow aspects of Samech. These tendencies create isolation, deny Hashem's existence, and contradict and negate our connection to others.
- Not giving or accepting feedback, being secretive, and hiding from the truth, can all lead to isolation, loneliness, and a delusional lifestyle. In severe cases, it can even produce catatonia. This is a serious shadow aspect of Samech.
- Being overly dependent in relationships is also a shadow aspect of Samech. This leads to feeling wounded and angry, and causes you to place blame on your partner, friends, or family for what is your own making.

Right Actions for Samech

- Give and receive help and support where you have resisted in the past. Take a step toward interdependence.
- Pray for Divine assistance. Walk in the woods. Listen to a bird. Notice how dogs act with their owner.
- Demonstrate your connection to humanity. Share without being asked. It is not important how others respond to it. It is only important that you share it. Create the environment for this sharing.



Before the Baal Shem Tov passed away, his disciples heard him whispering on his deathbed, but there was no one near him. As they moved closer to try and figure out what he was saying, they heard him murmur a verse from Psalm 36: 'Let not the foot of pride overtake me.' After he passed on, they realized who he was talking to. The evil inclination was ready to take away all the good the Baal Shem Tov had accomplished during his lifetime by causing him to be proud of his accomplishments and take full credit for them. Instead, the Baal Shem Tov chose to repeat this verse over and over to remind himself- and the angel of death- that he realized that without Hashem's help, one accomplishes nothing at all.

Ayin

Meaning : Eye and Fountain, spring in the earth

Focus: Enlightenment –Insight - Seeing the future

Number: 70

Calendar Connection: Tevet – January/February

When you choose Ayin, it means you are ready to open your eyes to see your uniqueness. You see the way out of your perception of oppression. You may previously have felt lost, been unclear or confused by what you saw as truth. It is now your time to see both the light and darkness within you. It is now your time to

see equality. Psalm 119; verse 18. "Open my eyes, that I may perceive the wonders of your teaching".

What is your perspective of the light and the dark within?

When you open your eyes to what is true within you, you will create an opening in your heart to see what is true outside of you. You may notice there is no outside or inside. This can be confusing. When teaching about this phenomenon, the Kabbalah says that the eye possesses five powers, a gift from Hashem. The right eye possesses five levels of kindness, whereas the left eye possesses five levels of sternness and force. Our right eye is open to heavenly forces and our left eye is open to the earth. This reflects the concept of Right Brain/Left Brain. In all teachings from the Kabbalah, we are told we cannot look at Hashem directly. Instead, we can see him through our spine, looking inside for alignment of heart and mind. Some sages say a third eye, invisible in the center of our forehead, connects to our spine and is how we see the Hashem's essence in all there is.

How are you showing your kindness and compassion?

How are you stern or forceful?

Ayin spelled with an Alef also means no-thing in that its essence cannot be described. It is ineffable. It can only be experienced. To those new to Kabbalah, the idea that all is no-thingness or emptiness may seem similar to Buddhism or other Eastern paths. However, Ayin, no-thingness, is the ultimate reality of all. It is the reality of Hashem. The Kabbalah teaches that when we are looking inward, we experience the infinite eye of Hashem directing us to ultimate fulfillment of our purpose. It is then that the I that have always been can witness. We can be the "I" that is the eye. It is at this time we are able to perceive without projections.

What event or feeling in your life cannot be described but is true?

By choosing Ayin, you are ready to envision your future. You can make it come alive to yourself and others. You are ready to be a leader that supports others to find their own vision. Sages were called the eyes of the group or organization because they were the only ones who could truly lead. They were masters of their internal environment.

Who experiences you as a leader?

Who do you experience as a leader?

Number 70

- The number 70 represents the totality of all attributes working in a harmonious manner.
- 70 is the actualization of the potential of 7.
- The average life span is 70 years.
- There are 70 names of God.
- An evolved person is one who has control of 70 levels of emotions.

Shadow Aspect of Ayin

- Taking action prematurely -- before looking out of both eyes and in all directions -- is a shadow aspect of Ayin. Many times our impulses control our behavior and we make the same mistake repeatedly, we feel regret and our self-esteem erode. As we continue this pattern, we are then spiritually blind.
- The evil eye is the name given to a transmission of negativity, usually without intention, when one is envious, jealous, and covets what others have. When unaware, we can be receiving or giving the "evil eye", the "ayin harah", "This is another shadow aspect of Ayin
- Seeing the world from a narrow, off balance perspective is also a shadow aspect of Ayin. When we act from our right eye only, we are totally idealistic and naïve. When we act from our left eye, we only see the materialistic perspective of our impulsive choices.

Right Actions

- Lead like a sage. Look at your life through both eyes and choose an action that benefits all?
- Reconnect with a person who you treated poorly because of jealousy or other negative feelings. Share yourself in a positive manner and let them know you regret past behavior.
- Try on what you perceive as your parent's perspective for a day and look at the world through their eyes. Share your experience with family members.



Once there was a man who had said awful things about someone. Realizing that he has done something awful, he goes to his rabbi and asks, "Rabbi, what can I do?" The rabbi thinks a bit and tells the man to bring him a feather pillow. The man brings the pillow, and the rabbi tells him to go outside, rip the pillow open, and shake out the feathers. The man does that. As he shakes out the feathers, the wind catches them, and they start flying everywhere. The man comes back to the rabbi and says, "I did as you said. Now what?." The rabbi says, "Now go back outside and pick up all the feathers." The man looks startled and says, "How can I? The wind took them! I don't even know where they are now." The rabbi says, "Exactly. Just like your words. Once they're out, it's impossible to get them back"

Pei

Meaning: Mouth

Focus: Communication

Number: 80

Calendar Connection: Thursday – 5th day of the week

When you choose Pei, you are ready to partner with Hashem to reform the world through words. Hashem created the world through words. Words have power to heal or wound. Once spoken, they cannot be recalled. The Kabbalah teaches that the effect words have on the emotional and spiritual environment cannot be quantified. Our eyes see the word before it is speakable, and the mouth speaks words before we see their effect. Words of wisdom spoken with sincerity and humility massage the organs. The Kabbalah teaches that words coming from the heart enter the heart, while words coming from fear enter our body as fear.

What words have you spoken causing you or others fear?

According to the Kabbalah, energy is released when words are spoken setting events in motion. These events can be positive or negative. This is similar to dropping a pebble in water and watching the ripples.

Where do these ripples end?

Energy precedes words. This means when we listen to people talk, we are really listening to their “streams of energy.” By choosing Pei, we are able to respond to these streams of energy with words that support the positive aspect of the energy of people’s words. Children hear the energy of words. They respond to seemingly negative words with love and caring, yet respond to seemingly positive declarations of love with the desire to hide or retreat from the speaker.

Do children know something we do not? What is it?

Pei is a double letter, meaning it has more than one sound, so it also has more than one message. These messages tell us when to speak and when to keep silent. This includes knowing when to offer positive supportive encouragement and when to offer “rebuke.” Rebuke means a reprimand or expression of criticism or disapproval. The Talmud, a Jewish book of commentary of the Torah, states that “to shame a person in public is akin to murder” We are obligated to “rebuke” a person when we truly care about them so that they can learn and grow. Choosing Pei at this time gives you the opportunity to achieve mastery and elegance in these communications.

Have you been “rebuked” and felt good about it?

Have you “rebuked” another and felt good about it?

Do you offer encouragement easily?

Through Pei, it is possible to find your voice, transcend your previous limitations and allow your truth to shape your future with your words in partnership with Hashem. This voice is your heart's voice, this truth is your unique truth, and this future is yours. Only you can live your life; only you can be the truth of your words. Kabbalists say that our purpose is to sing Hashem's praises.

What has happened to you when you thank Hashem and show gratitude for your life? What happens to those around you?

Moses had a speech impediment. The story is told that when Moses was a small child, the Pharaoh's brother saw how he could grow up to become more powerful than Pharaoh, and in fact, could destroy the people of Egypt. Moses' future father in law happened to be on the scene and he proposed a test of the boy. Moses would be given the choice of picking up a piece of gold or a burning coal, if he chose the gold, it would indicate he had knowledge and sense and would be killed. The child reached for the gold, but angelic interference pushed his hand towards the coal, which he put in his mouth and burned. He lived. This created a speech impediment and Moses began to stutter. He was not seen as a threat. His stuttering disappeared during the time he spoke the words that Hashem put into his mouth.

When Moses led the Jewish people out of Egypt, he bonded with the Divine Presence, the feminine attributes and aspect of Hashem, the Shechinah. He did this in order to talk to Hashem. The oral teachings of Judaism portray Moses as a man of Hashem on intimate terms with Hashem, demonstrated by their speaking together, face to face.

The number for Pei is 80.

- Moses was 80 years old when he led the people out of Egypt.

Shadow Aspect of Pei

- Many times we behave as if our words are "the truth" rather than our truth. When this happens we close our minds and our hearts to the wisdom of others. This leads to an insulated, self-contained world with rhetoric rather than healing words.
- Gossiping is such a dangerous prohibition in the Kabbalah, it is given the name of Lashon Hara. This means the "evil tongue" and is another shadow aspect of Pei. Speaking badly of another with negative intention in your heart leads to hardening of the heart. When this happens, we are unable to give our love to others and our words become infused with a victim

perspective. Gossip can ruin another's reputation as well as that of the gossip and the one listening.

- Withholding words of love out of fear of commitment or love is a shadow aspect of Pei. This fear creates alienation and sarcasm as well as skepticism and doubt.

Right Actions for Pei:

- Speak words that tell your truth to everyone. You do not need to be intimate or even share your personal story. Just tell your truth in as simple a way as possible.
- Make amends for biting or negative speech to people in your life – or people from the past. Apologize for the wound of the words and share what is true today.
- Speak concisely and simply. This can put you in the here and now when you speak to people. By not adding or withholding in your speech, you can experience yourself in present time. Do this as much as possible.



Rabbi Israel Baal Shem Tov was the venerated founder of the Chassidic movement. He succeeded in bringing the hidden Jewish mystical teachings to the masses, in a form that was more 'user friendly' than any time in history. He lay dying on the sacred festival of Shavuot, the day the Torah was given on Mount Sinai. His entire life, with all its accomplishments flashed before him. His disciples saw his lips in constant motion, and came closer to see if he needed anything. Instead, when they bent their ears toward him, they heard him murmuring a verse from psalms over and over. The phrase was from psalm 37: 'Let not the foot of pride overtake me.' The disciples then realized what was happening. All one's life, a holy person tries to do more and more good in the world. He or she strives to overcome all temptations to sin, either by commission or omission. Finally at the end of one's life, the only 'weapon' that the Yetzer Harah, the inclination toward evil, has to conquer a Tzadik, a righteous person, is the temptation of pride. If the Baal Shem Tov would have

succumbed to this temptation, all his holy work would have been tainted. So even in his last moments of life, the holy Tzadik needed to resist the force of pride.

Tzadi

Meaning : The righteous one – to hunt

Focus : Bringing thoughts and words into righteous actions

Number: 90

Calendar connection: Shevat - February/March

When you choose Tzadi, you are ready to serve Hashem and give up the illusion of surface appearances. The Kabbalah teaches that at any given time there are 36 righteous people in the world. These people are humble and imbued with Hashem's principles. They are called Tzadikim. Without these 36 people, the suffering in the world would be unbearable. The Kabbalah also says that everyone has the energy of a potential Tzadik. This energy can ignite at any time. Because you have chosen Tzadi, you have decided this is your time to be a "righteous" person.

Do you know anyone who is "righteous?"

What does being "righteous" mean to you?

How are you "righteous?"

Righteous people commit to a higher value. Their spiritual consciousness has the element of a hunter. This hunter is always searching for the broken fragments of the shattered vessels of Hashem's Divine light. When you look in the mirror, hunt for hidden righteousness in your eyes. When you look in the eyes of another, hunt for their Divine light. By doing this, you might also see the broken aspect of their soul, and be with them. By doing this, you treat each person with a deep love and respect. You will be tuned into realms that are beyond the awareness of most people.

Have you been a "hunter" of this divine light in others?

The Kabbalah teaches that before a soul descends into earth she makes a promise to Hashem to only do right actions. When we begin to react and respond to our life situation, we tend to forget this promise. By choosing Tzadi, you are remembering your promise to Hashem.

Do you remember the promises you made to Hashem?

You might think that by being righteous you will be forced to live a life of isolation or loneliness. Yet, by meditating on the Tzadi, its shape, its meaning and its purpose, you will experience the transformation of your psyche. Remember, this is the language of creation and as such, the unlimited potential of Tzadi will recreate itself in your being. When this occurs, your beliefs about loneliness and isolation will disappear.

Can you remember a time when one of your beliefs changed instantaneously? What happened?

There are many stories connected to the letter Tzadi and most of them are true. Here is one of these stories. Imagine being in an airport and striking up a conversation with a person who is cleaning the floors and counters. You find yourself sharing about your family as does he/she. It is a short conversation. When it is over, you feel open and connected to yourself and the people around you. This humble person you just spoke with could be a Tzadik, one of the 36 righteous ones. Remember, we are a Divine image created by Hashem. Now that you have chosen Tzadi, your will and Hashem's are ready to be aligned.

How can you align your will with Hashem's? Do you experience this alignment much of the time?

The shape and form of the letter Tzadi are the closest to that of Aleph. It lets us know that when we are humble and righteous, we are closest to the One. Being close to Hashem is our birthright. Yet, much of the time, we don't have that experience. In order to consciously live in that energy, we need to "do." We need to take action. The Kabbalah teaches that many words in Hebrew that mean service, good deeds, and charity, have the letter Tzadi in them. By putting these concepts into action, you are performing mitzvot (action-connections), and becoming infused with the living energy of that direct channel to Hashem.

What service do you perform that is natural for you?

The number for Tzadi is 90.

- Total consciousness
- Age of Spiritual enlightenment
- First trimester of pregnancy
- In atomic numbers, the number 90 is the isotope 232 which is used as a power source in nuclear reactors
- Expresses a progression ascending from the simplest and most primitive, feminine energy to the transformed symbols of womanhood— both social and mythical.

The Shadow Aspect of Tzadi:

- A rigid expression of extreme righteousness or puffed up, ego driven self-righteousness is a shadow aspect of Tzadi and harms those it touches. When this forcefulness of will and ego is projected on another, it hardens the heart.
- Unrealistic expectations, and rigid self-imposed standards to be “good” all the time, lead to self-judgment and lack of joy. Sainthood is not an aspect of the Kabbalah. Humans who attempt a life without mistakes or learning are unable to achieve compassion and authentic righteousness.
- It is easy to succumb to unconscious pride by “being good.” As people become more spiritually evolved, they can lose their self-awareness. They lose sight of how they affect others in their search for meaning. They see their way of serving as the “right” way and all others as “mistaken.” They can also forget that life is a series of experiences and teachings.

.Right Actions for Tzadi:

- Have an experience that is just pure fun. Allow yourself to have this experience without it having to be meaningful.
- Treat the people you meet in places such as gas stations, grocery stores, movie theaters, etc. as if they are Tzadikim. Be the hunter and see their righteousness.
- Examine your relationships. Give yourself permission to be satisfied and content with your family and friends.
- Keeping your unique quality of righteousness in mind, select a few of the gifts you have to offer and share them without an agenda.



Once Rabbi Shneur Zalman, the first Chabad Rabbi, was studying on the second floor of his house, while his son Dov Ber was studying on the first floor next to the crib of his baby Menachem Mendel. The baby started crying louder and louder, but Dov Ber was so engrossed in his learning that he was oblivious to the world around him. The grandfather, Rabbi Zalman, came running down from the second floor, shook his son out of his reverie, and reprimanded him with a message that has universal import. "One should never be so engrossed in higher worlds that one forgets to hear the cry of a child!"

KUF

Meaning: Monkey, holiness

Focus: Retrieve the shards that were broken

Number: 100

Calendar Connection: Month of Adar

When you choose Kuf, you are inviting worldly, physical, holiness into your life. Because the foot of Kuf extends below the line in the Torah, it goes into the depths of the human experience. For many, this is called the lower realm of reality, the realm of “evil.” Through the teachings of the Kabbalah we learn that Hashem pulls us up from the depths of this shadow world and lifts us to extraordinary heights when we perform Tikkun Alum (repairing the world). This can be in the form of kindness, compassion, keeping our agreements, charity, and more.

What do you do that lifts you out of your personal darkness?

Where is your challenge?

The Kabbalah teaches that because of this paradox in the letter Kuf, it has earned the right to begin the word Kadosh (holiness) and Kiddush, the prayer for the dead. Choosing Kuf means you mourn and pray for all who have died while at the same time, make a pledge for peace. You are prepared to give up what stands between you and peace. You are in a place of readiness to choose the sacred in the physical. Your choice of peace acts as a sacrifice, a holy sacrifice. Your peaceful choices open up a channel for you to see the holy spark in all who are broken. Kuf symbolizes the reality of fallen sparks. Because there is an innate spark of holiness in the core of each broken shard, Hashem’s entire created world is guaranteed elevation and redemption when we choose Tikkun Alum.

What stands between you and peace?

Where in your life do you need to choose peace? Is it a difficult choice? Why?

Kuf is the only Hebrew letter that goes below the line of writing on a page, symbolizing the depths of the physical. The Kabbalah teaches that Kuf is able to remove the light from the world of evil, the Klipah, which then eliminates this shadow control over our lives. Even darkness is surrounded by light. Hashem created both good and evil, so we could consciously choose our path. We know monkeys, other animals and angels cannot choose. They follow their instinct, their programming. By choosing, we can create our own happiness. When we choose well, we achieve what is called mind over matter and overcome our personal doubts. We enter the light of Hashem. It then becomes easier to choose joy.

Do you have a place of darkness within that renders you feeling helpless?

Another meaning for Kuf is monkey. Kuf purifies the physical through this meaning. It makes the animal aspect of humanity holy. A monkey is considered by

the Kabbalah to be in between a human and an animal. Monkeys imitate. So do humans. Ancient sages have said, "Like a monkey in the face of man." This refers to people who unsuccessfully imitate someone other than themselves. True seekers, however, are people who want to remember and know themselves. They do not want to imitate people from their past, or people they admire. They know how important it is to be without veils, to be transparent.

Many great people have imitated their heroes to learn a pattern of behavior that becomes their own. This imitation is more a way to access their Higher Self rather than become someone else.

Do you have heroes? Who are they?

What do your heroes symbolize?

The number for Kuf is 100.

- The completion of one and 10
- Decimal system
- Most systems of measurement

Shadow Aspect of Kuf

- Wearing a mask is a shadow aspect of Kuf. After a while, it becomes difficult to know what is masked and what is real. Inside, one may be screaming for freedom, while on the outside there sits a "happy face." This leads to desperation and confusion about personal identity. If continued, this can also lead to feelings of non-existence and brokenness.
- Being overly attached to one's own "brand" of holiness is another shadow aspect of Kuf. Whatever ground a human stands upon can be transformed into a holy ground. Yet, many believe their own rituals and beliefs are the only true holiness. This leads to permanent separation and a contracted world. This holiness becomes form without substance. One becomes bitter and feels maligned and alone. Eventually they forgo the experience of Hashem's love.
- Being focused on death, mourning, and tragedy is yet another shadow aspect of Kuf. Leaving the world of life and joy to move into the shadow world of

darkness is dangerous. Not being able to experience self-examination and laughter leads to self-pity and martyrdom as well. These states of being create an experience of “evil,” violence, and coldness that is projected onto others.

Right Actions for Kuf

- Remove any masks you’ve been hiding behind and open to receive what is “so” from your environment. This can range from love to sunshine, from conversations to silence. Watch your response while not wearing any mask.
- Speak with others who have different perspectives on holiness. Take in their brand of holiness without petitioning for your own point of view. It is okay to allow other perspectives to open your mind to a state of not knowing.
- Feel your true feelings whether they be sadness, grief, or joy. Allow all to synergize and influence your life. Choose life.



The story is told that when Moses led the Israelites out of Egypt and spoke to Hashem face to face,’ other nations heard about his greatness and wanted to discover the ‘secret to his success.’ One king commissioned an artist to go into the desert and paint a portrait of this amazing man so that his wizards could study the details of his face and unearth his unique traits. The artist dutifully fulfilled his assignment; but when he returned to the king and showed the picture to his wizards, they proclaimed, ‘Your majesty, this is the face of a man with the most horrible traits we have ever seen.’ The king was furious and assumed the Israelites had played a trick on the artist, and shown him the wrong man. The king

ordered the artist to go back and verify who the real Moses was. He did as he was told and sure enough, he had painted the correct portrait in the first place. The artist confronted Moses with the 'reading' of the king's wizards, and asked him to explain how someone like him could be such a revered leader. Moses told him candidly: 'yes, it's true. I was born with all the characteristics you describe. However, by choosing Hashem and learning about myself, I was able to transform those despicable traits into a person refined enough to be able to encounter and reflect the face of Hashem.

Reish

Meaning: Wicked, poor, evil, head or beginning, inherit

Number: 200

Focus: Clarifying choices

Calendar Connection: Friday – 6th day of the week

When you choose Reish, it means you have the capability to transform negativity and “amorality” into healing and goodness. It also means you can now make way for new beginnings. Reish is a letter of extreme transformative possibilities both negative and positive. Although it is located near the end of the Alef-Bet, Reish means beginning.

What new beginnings have you experienced?

Are there negative situations you wish to transform?

The Kabbalah teaches that wisdom begins with the fear of Hashem. This Kabbalistic concept of fear is not familiar to us. Imagine this fear as alive, similar to a lightning bolt. This bolt of fear shocks the ego. It then turns into awe, which breaks through the patterns keeping us from having new “beginnings”. These new “beginnings” are paradigm shifts that allow us to experience the wisdom of Hashem. Are there recent experiences that allowed you to have an “aha” of this nature?

The Kabbalah teaches that we are born knowing “selflessness.” Selflessness is an inner experience of the soul and serves as a container to hold new flashes of insight and wisdom. Fear, the beginning of wisdom, corresponds to the source of this state of selflessness. Fear “shocks” ego, dissolving the hardness of the heart that prevents us from perceiving outside of our own reality. This “shock” allows us to see outside of our limited perspective and assists us in recognizing the Divine in all creation.

Have you experienced “ego shock?”

What was the result?

By definition, Reish also means “wicked”, “evil”, “poor”, and “head”. Fear can be disguised as resistance to the light. By fearing Hashem, and removing this disguise, it is possible to return to him through acts of repentance. These words and concepts may seem harsh and outdated in today’s world of spoken light and easy spirituality. Yet, fear of the light is omnipresent in our lives. It can shatter our pictures of ourselves. It can stop us from accepting love from our friends and family. It defines our external world. By allowing love and rejecting the “poverty of our soul,” we can reclaim our “selflessness.” This reclamation then gives us the power to transform our negativity into compassion and acceptance.

What are the ways that you are “selfless?”

Our minds create context for all situations. The basis of all human creation begins with an interpretation of experience. This interpretation becomes the context for the story of our life. We then choose behaviors from our interpretation that continue to support what is often referred to as “our story.” This “story” becomes our reality. When we allow fear of Hashem to shock our ego, we can consistently enjoy new beginnings and let go of our story.

Rosh Hashanah is the Jewish New Year and begins with the letter Reish. This holiday is about new beginnings. It is the time of the year when anyone can return to Hashem. Although this can happen at any time, the energy that surrounds Rosh Hashanah precipitates this return. When we completely atone for our mistakes, we become a “Rosh,” a leader for our own growth. In fact, one of the prayers during the Rosh Hashanah meal is to act as the “head” and not as the “tail” in the coming year. This means leading in righteous actions and not following others in poor behavior. Rosh Hashanah is the Kabbalistic celebration of the birthday of the world.

What celebrations do you observe that lead you to take “right” actions?

Hashem’s desire for the world had a context, a head. This context is the physical, intellectual, emotional and spiritual environment of the world. Breishit, a word in the beginning of Genesis, shows us that we create our lives in context at all times. How we interpret our life situation determines our experience. The same situation, given a different context presents a myriad of possibilities. This is the beauty of all creation. What appears to be a piece of marble becomes the statue of David to the artist Michelangelo.

The number for Reish is 200.

Shadow side of Reish

- When we deny what is going on in our lives and pretend to have no fear of Hashem, we resist being in the light. This denial eventually snowballs into a solid structure that can only be melted with fear of Hashem. Remember, fear is awe.
- Worshiping our attachments by defending and protecting them from is another shadow aspect of Reish. Attachments to material, spiritual, physical or emotional energy and objects lead to a lack of wisdom and selfishness. The context of this life-style is hardening of heart and mind. This hardening creates brittle thinking and un-experienced feelings. Negativity and hurtful behavior is the result.
- Sin is knowingly choosing actions that will hurt the soul. The concept of sin, although seemingly antiquated, is still present in the collective consciousness of the mind. This is a shadow aspect of Reish. Although sin is in the heart and mind of the "sinner," the effect of negative behavior on the environment and the people in that environment is palpable.

Right action for Reish

- Recognize your true emptiness. Identify an attachment and choose to let it go. Notice your reaction to this choice. Take the actions needed to make this change.
- Allow your natural goodness to reassert itself. Choose to take an action based solely on your goodness.
- Pray or meditate with the love of Hashem in your heart and mind. Go deep into your experience and embrace any thoughts and feelings that arise. You may receive a glimpse of infinity. This can occur at any time.



A Rabbi was sitting with his disciples eating the “third meal,” at what was considered the holiest moment of the week, the Sabbath day right before sunset. The Rabbi was teaching a mystical discourse about the four worlds of creation, the highest of which is called “Olam Atzilut,” the world of emanation. The disciples were concentrating with intense focus. Suddenly the Rabbi began to cough persistently. His young son brought him some water to drink, but the Rabbi waved him away, saying, “In the world of Atzilut no one needs to drink water.” The

young boy replied politely but firmly, "Tatte (daddy) in the world of Atzilut no one coughs either."

Shin

Meaning: Fire, tooth, change, year, sleep, teach, two, sharp,

Number: 300

Focus: Finding changeless essence

Calendar Connection: Summer

When you choose Shin, it means you have an unfaltering awareness of the natural rhythms of the seasons and of the human need for wholeness. In order for this wholeness to occur, you are prepared to overcome the challenge of dualistic thinking. You know that although our planet is moving toward wholeness and harmony, at the same time we are seriously engaged in wars, bigotry, genocide, political deviousness and more. We have the choice to look at this as good and evil, right and wrong or simply as degrees of totality.

What "right and wrong" thinking is most difficult for you to digest?

Shin has more meanings than any other Hebrew letter.

A central meaning of Shin is change. You are aware that change is part of the natural rhythm of life. What doesn't change is reality; and reality is Hashem. The Kabbalah teaches that when Hashem created the world, he put before us a challenge --- to find "changeless essence" in the physical world. This changeless essence is Him. Change is the illusion. Yet, to live in the physical world, we live as if change is the reality and at times as if Hashem is the illusion. Eastern philosophies stress these teachings as well. .

What personal experiences have led to know Hashem is reality?

Paradoxically, the letter Shin is used in Kabbalistic meditation as a symbol of Divine, never changing, light. In this meditation, Shin is commonly associated with the element of fire. It is imagined hovering above the head of the person meditating as shooting flames. When we think of a flame we can see its two aspects. The inner part of the flame stays constant, while the outer flame is continuously in a state of movement. The Kabbalah says, "In the world to come, the changeless essence will reveal itself within the flame."

When you meditate, what do you focus on? Is it your breath, an image, a sound, etc.?

Another meaning of Shin is tooth or fang. When we chew on anything, we decompose it; yet, the essence of what we chew does not decompose. Whether we chew on food, thoughts, or feelings, we retain the essence of that which we decompose, whether by mouth or mind. This is a prevalent concept in kosher animal slaughter. The Kabbalah teaches that the essence of the food and liquid we eat and drink stays and becomes part of us. The name of the person who performs ritual slaughter of animals is *Shochet*. It too, begins with a Shin.

What do you chew on when you get into bed at night? What essence is still with you in the morning when you awaken?

Another word that begins with Shin is Shalom, meaning peace and wholeness. Shalom is also a name for Hashem. This Shalom or peace, presents itself most dominantly on Shabbat, or the Sabbath – another word that begins with a Shin. The Kabbalah teaches that the Sabbath is a taste of the world to come and allows humans the opportunity to give up dualistic thinking for 25 hours at a time.

Is it possible for you to experience both peace and war at the same time? What is that like?

The number for Shin is 300, the completion of the number three.

The Shadow Aspect of Shin:

- Corrupting spiritual truths by personal distortion disguised as knowing or excessive humility is a shadow aspect of Shin. Many religious zealots preach of the fires of hell, when their audience does not believe their rhetoric. If one looks closely, they can see the preacher's own fire of hell. As humans, we cannot know all there is to know, and by tricking ourselves in that manner, we distort our strengths into foolish absolutes. We then lose our ability to experience the essence of reality, Hashem.
- Lack of joy is another shadow aspect of Shin. Without the cleansing flame of a continuous intention of self-awareness, and growth, there cannot be joy. Joy is different than externally motivated happiness that comes and goes. Continuous lack of joy eventually turns that cleansing flame into ash.
- Greed, constant distractions, biting words, shallow connections, rigid beliefs, and an unwillingness to dive into the depths of the unchanging essence of Hashem, is yet another shadow aspect of Shin. Without the experience of depth both with the self and with others, the eternal flame of Shin cannot be experienced. Without this depth, people become robotic, unable to feel the joy and humility of life.

Right Actions for Shin

- Speak your simple truth in all situations of change and chaos. Notice what happens to any thoughts of distortion or embellishment not spoken. Be aware of your desire to say more or less.
- Meditate on a flame. Notice the interplay between the unchanging inner flame and the changing outer flame.
- Discover the inherent goodness in each interaction or situation you take part in. Allow that goodness to determine your action.
- Seek your spiritual path with consistency and vigor. Be aware of other's truths' and find joy in the similarities and differences



Every book of Biblical and Rabbinic commentary begins with the letter Beit, the second letter of the Alef-Bet. You will not find a Hebrew sacred text starting with the letter Aleph, the first letter of the Alef-Bet. This is because even when you think you have completed your learning and have gotten all the way to the letter Tav, the end of the Hebrew Alef-Bet, you have actually not even mastered the Aleph, the very beginning.

Tav

Focus: Living in state of duality knowing there is absolute truth

Meaning: A sign, a mark

Number: 400

Calendar Connection: Saturday – 7th day of the week

When you choose Tav, it means you are balanced in your quest to align with universal reality, the reality of Hashem. The only absolute truth is Hashem. Through Tav, we have a taste of that truth. Hashem is the real story. When we meditate on Tav, we understand that knowledge is not the end of knowing. In fact, it is the beginning of the next cycle of learning. Though Tav is the final letter of the Hebrew alphabet, truth is our final destination.

What does truth mean to you?

Can you tell when another is speaking their truth?

Tav represents the end of one stage of completion in our life and the beginning of the next stage. We are always in a state of completion. Becoming complete or whole may mean leaving something we are attached to. Many experience that as a death. Sometimes it may be so. Becoming complete with a particular situation allows us to see it for what it is. . However, we still know there is always more than meets our eye; we cannot ever know Hashem from the limits of our human mind. If we can describe an experience, it is not the truth of Hashem. Hashem is unknowable. Truth is the seal of Hashem.

What situations do you need to complete?

What situations, relationships, etc. have been difficult for you to complete?

Tav means seal. Many Hebrew Holy words begin with the Tav. Tikun Olam means to “make whole.” The Kabbalah teaches that in order for creation to occur, matter was embedded with shards of holiness and light. It becomes the task of humans to liberate those shards of holiness, elevate them, and return them to Hashem. Until that occurs, we are trapped in our minds and cannot see a larger truth.

Are you overlooking the existence of holiness in your life? Where?

What larger truth do you connect into to feel complete?

Another word that begins with Tav is “tefila” which means prayer. The Kabbalah instructs us to pray and meditate with heart and devotion so that our intention will reach Hashem. Because Tav is a symbol reflecting the center of our psyches, it is the receptacle of creation for all our human truth.

What is your intention when you pray? Do you ask for something from Hashem? Are you giving thanks?

The number for Tav is 400

Shadow Aspect of Tav

- Being in an overconfident and arrogant state is a shadow aspect of Tav. Many people who are in this state see themselves as “perfect” not needing to change anything about themselves. This way of being can be devastating to our perfect person, as others see what they are blind to. Instead, the perfect person tries to change others so they themselves do not have to change. Over time, they become incapable of change.
- Thinking all is complete when in fact, there is quite a bit of disarray in one’s life is also a shadow aspect of Tav. It is a form of denial.
- Staying in a situation when truths are not being shared can damage them permanently. This is a total avoidance of intimacy. Marriages fail, children leave home angry and hurt, and businesses fail when a person is unaware of other’s feelings, thoughts, and dreams. Putting one’s “seal” on a lie is the same as saying no to Hashem. This too, is a shadow aspect of Tav.

Right Actions for Tav

- Be humble in the face of Hashem. Allow yourself to meditate, pray and spend time each day with Hashem. Write down your thoughts or share them with a friend.
- When asked a question, tell your truth with nothing added or withheld. The power of your truth lies in its results. As you do this watch your level of intimacy increase and your self-confidence grow.
- Complete relationships that are keeping you from being in present time with others in your life. This means taking care of leftover thoughts and actions.

Authors Notes

Judith Orloff, M.Ed.

When I was a small child, I lost a mitten and was inconsolable. My mom offered hugs, new mittens, ice cream and lots of love. When able to speak, I said the lost mitten would be lonely for its mate. I thought it was alive and had feelings. I later discovered in my work that many children feel that way about lost toys or clothes. When I read fairy tales, I often felt bad for the wicked stepsisters and the wicked queens or witches in the stories. I couldn't understand why they were so mean. I also didn't understand why the heroes

and heroines of these stories were always so good. These are just two examples of how I thought as a child.

Working with Lubavitch of Bucks County, co-designing programs about G-d, holiness and the practical application of the Kabbalah, my love of writing, and meeting Yehudis Fishman and Jasmyne Boswell, led me to write a book about the Power of the Sacred Living Letters, the Hebrew Alef- Bet.

I had many Ah-has' while working with Lubavitch of Bucks County. I realized all of Hashem's creation has a soul, and there is a shadow aspect of all living creatures. I also learned that we each have a moment-to-moment opportunity to tip the scales into goodness through right actions.

Jasmyne and I realized although we both followed spiritual paths most of our lives, and were Jewish by birth, neither one of us knew much about the mystical aspect of Judaism. I had only recently been learning how to read Hebrew and wanted to study the meaning of the letters. Together with Jasmyne and Yehudis, I have been on a journey into the core of Judaism, the Sacred Living Letters, and this is only a beginning. What a joy to discover Judaism has a mystical aspect that is unending and infinite.

Writing this book led me to many personal and transpersonal discoveries. I know I am a spark of G-d, of Hashem. This discovery obligates me to do right actions, and embrace shadow aspects of myself rather than project them onto others. I can no longer pretend that my gifts and talents come from anything other than Hashem and false humility or pride seems to fade over time. On a transpersonal level, I understand that all of G-d's creation has this same spark of Hashem, including inanimate objects. What a concept. To recognize that Styrofoam, plastic, and all that is here has G-d in it, has shifted how I live my life.

I am a spiritual guide, coach, non-dual, transpersonal therapist and author. I know we are all connected through the always present, no-thingness of Hashem. I cherish my time with clients and feel privileged and honored to accompany them on their journey. I wish you blessings and love in your personal exploration of The Sacred Living Letters.

JASMYNE BOSWELL

Writing The Power of the Sacred Letters opened my heart and mind to a deeper perspective of life and its preciousness. Although I was brought up in a Reform Jewish household, my parents never belonged to a temple or synagogue. We did celebrate Passover, and were allowed to stay home from school on High Holidays, but my knowledge of Judaism was very limited. I became interested in spirituality in my late 20's, studying various forms of Psychology, Hinduism, and Buddhism, never knowing that my own religion had deep mystical and spiritual roots.

It wasn't until I heard talk about the Kabbalah in my early 50's and started reading and going to lectures that my interest peaked. I was excited to learn that my religious heritage was steeped in wisdom, dating back to the beginning of time. My discovery of these ancient teachings opened a door to my great appreciation of Judaism.

My inspiration for writing *The Power of the Sacred Letters* came from my personal interest in learning about the Kabbalah. I loved losing myself in the myriad of writings on the subject. I wanted a deep, personal experience of its wisdom and didn't have the time to invest in reading all the formal texts.

For years I used the Celtic Runes, Oracles known by most spiritual seekers, on a semi-regular basis. I enjoyed the immediacy of the teachings that gave me the momentary guidance I was seeking. However, after time, I knew what the rune I picked would say before even reading the text. One morning, a thought came to me while I was meditating—a Kabbalistic version of the Runes. I could learn the Kabbalah through the wisdom imbedded in the Hebrew Alphabet. If I got excited about learning the Sacred letters through this medium, others might as well.

Judith and I had been talking for months about doing a project together. We each had experience in many personal and spiritual growth disciplines and were both interested in the Kabbalah. Because we enjoyed and respected each other's life experiences and perspectives, we knew we could learn from one another. We would bring our complimentary gifts together in the spirit of Kabbalah. This partnership has deepened over the course of the last year and a half surpassing any expectations we may have had, wanted or knew was possible. It has truly been a gift from Hashem.